Spinoza's Life and Doctrine

A Contribution to the History of Thought in the Seventeenth Century

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Translated from the Danish

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Preface

The writing of this little book is owed to the esteemed publisher's invitation to include *[III]* Spinoza in his series of "cultural-historical personalities." I have not been blind to the difficulties of such a task. Spinoza's significance for the history of culture is closely bound up with his place in the history of abstract speculation, and it cannot rightly be understood without a closer insight into his philosophy. I have tried to give as easily comprehensible a survey of it as possible, and I have laid out the book so that in the first three parts the reader makes a preliminary acquaintance with Spinoza's most important ideas before a connected account of his doctrine is given in the last part.

We have in our literature a thorough and penetrating monograph on Spinoza by the late Professor Brøchner. Through the clear light in which that work sets the various elements of Spinoza's philosophy, it holds a high place in the great literature on Spinoza. But it is not easily accessible to one who wishes to make Spinoza's acquaintance without rather advanced philosophical preparation. I have conceived my little book as a kind of introduction to Brøchner's, in that I have renounced completeness and thoroughness in *[IV]* detail, as well as learned documentation. I have, however, been able to use what was not yet available in complete form when Brøchner wrote his treatise: the interesting work "On God and Man," which shows us the first form of Spinoza's philosophy and points clearly to its historical presuppositions, as well as the letters from and to Spinoza that have been found since and that shed light on several points in his biography. Van Vloten has collected everything pertaining to this in his book "Ad Benedicti de Spinoza opera qvæ supersunt omnia supplementum" (Amstelodami 1862).

The standpoint from which I regard and judge Spinoza's philosophy differs from Brøchner's. My late teacher, of whom I have so often been reminded while working on this book, stood nearer to Spinoza as a speculative philosopher than I do. His criticism is

therefore directed, not against the very principle of Spinoza's speculation, but against the inconsistencies in its execution. I had to go further, not only by virtue of my own philosophical views, but also because I set myself the task of indicating the significance of Spinoza's theories in the light of the later history of the sciences, and especially of the research of our own time. But in spite of this more far-reaching criticism, my admiration for the great thinker has grown rather than diminished. Spinoza may be said to have celebrated a double resurrection, after having lain for more than a century "like a dead
[V] dog": the first time at the end of the eighteenth century, in the philosophical, poetic and religious awakening; the second time in our own day, through the great hypotheses of natural science and the reawakening of philosophy after the slackness that the surfeit of speculation had brought about. It is characteristic of his position in the history of thought that two such different epochs could meet in adherence and sympathy toward him. In many ways his method and his way of thinking are even directly opposed to those that prevail in the research of our time; but here we have an example of how—to use an image I have employed somewhere in *this* book—workers who dig a tunnel, each from his own side, meet in the middle, provided only that each, from his own starting point, goes forward along the right path.

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Harald Høffding.

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Introduction

The great importance of the history of science is being more and more recognized in our day. Not only does a strong historical interest go hand in hand with the interest in the scientific problems themselves—a wish to know the earlier state of these problems and the way in which they were formerly treated—but it holds of many questions that they are first rightly understood when one sees how they have historically arisen and been conceived. Often the path by which a scientific truth has gradually been won is the same one that, on a shortened scale, must be traversed by everyone who wants to make it his own. But there is surely no science for which history has such great importance as for philosophy. This must be ascribed, first, to the fact that philosophy is richer in endeavors than in results. Given a sum of results, one can to a certain degree forget when, how and by whom they were won. The Pythagorean theorem can be fully appropriated even if one has never heard anything of Pythagoras. But where the chief weight must be laid on the ever renewed striving,—where it is precisely a matter of sharpening the sting of the problems in order to set thought in motion anew, there historical orientation has a peculiar importance. The earlier attempts become partly models, partly warnings for the later ones. It lies, further, in the nature of philosophical ideas that they often come into the world too early. They are often ideals, set up and won by a bold speculation that goes beyond the actual results of real knowledge and anticipates a goal that in reality can be reached only laboriously and after long ages. Since the final task of philosophy is to develop a coherent and comprehensive world-view, philosophical ideas are directed toward the unity and the whole of things; but they presuppose, besides, that the nature and the interrelations of particular things are known. The same thing, moreover, happens within the real sciences too, with the views and hypotheses that express the connection of phenomena and give their explanation. Huyghens put forward the so-called wave theory

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in the seventeenth century to explain the phenomena of light, and only in our century has it won general recognition. Lamarck's theory of the origin of species became an object of wider attention and assent only through Darwin's investigations. The significance of scientific ideas, in philosophy as in the other sciences, depends on how far they have really been drawn from nature and carried through with consistency and clarity. If they have roots in reality and inner consistency, their victory will come, early or late.

Spinoza's philosophy is of great interest in both respects. It is no accident that the
[3] call to commemorate the two-hundredth anniversary of his death by raising his statue has found support around Europe, not only among philosophers by profession, but also among eminent representatives of the real sciences. For his system does not merely have a classical significance through its purity and clear coherence, so that we can learn from it, as from a model, how a scientific world-view must be built. That would not be enough to awaken a general interest. It is precisely the systematic form of a philosophical doctrine that most readily falls prey to transience. We can move about in Spinozism, as in the other philosophical systems, much as we do in the buildings of antiquity, which we admire and from which we can learn much, although we would not ourselves build in the same way now. But in our day one cannot study philosophy and general natural science without one's thought being led back to Spinoza in many ways. Many of his fundamental thoughts may be said to have found their confirmation in the results of recent science. Out of the perishable form of the system the kernel of the ideas develops, and it is then of great interest to see how, by what method and through what motives Spinoza came to the ideas at which we have now arrived, in part by other paths.

But Spinoza's ideas were more to him than objects of theoretical speculation. They fused with his personal view of life, and precisely the seriousness with which he asserted the right and the capacity of scientific inquiry to determine the view of life became
[4] decisive for his fate and brought him into conflict with the ecclesiastical authority, which here recognizes only the right of tradition. His personal life and his character thereby acquire a significance in philosophical respects as well. Philosophy is, to be sure, first of all a theoretical concern; but it cannot and must not give up the demand that the truth it has recognized become determinative for life; it is to act as a salt against the insipidity of dogmatism. It is therefore its pride that it can point in its history to figures like Spinoza's, and we shall see in what follows how his character and biography have played no small

part in the struggle for the legitimacy of free inquiry.

As already indicated, a philosophical system must be judged from a twofold side. One must examine its inner coherence and consistency, and its agreement with reality as this is accessible to us through scientific experience. Neither of these two points of view can be dispensed with. What thought seeks in philosophy is a scientific conception of life and the world, in which all the particular given facts are joined into a whole and brought into inner coherence with one another. Unity and coherence must therefore be present; not only logical contradictions, but also what is detached, isolated and merely empirical is unphilosophical. But this unity and coherence must not be bought by setting aside essential facts, nor by distorting and arbitrarily reinterpreting them. The principle that lies at the basis of a philosophical system must therefore be chosen so that, in its further unfolding, it can contain and illuminate everything that stands firm through scientific experience. At different times philosophy has laid different weight on these two sides. *[5]* The dogmatic and idealistic tendency in philosophy lays the chief weight on the carrying through of the principle; the critical and realistic tendency, by contrast, lays the chief weight on agreement with experience and on the grounding of the principle itself. The last-named tendency seems more and more to be gaining the upper hand, and it is in any case the prevailing one in our day.

The history of philosophy presents us with a series of systems, each of which lays its own principle at the basis. Which principle is seized upon in the particular system is naturally not arbitrary. On a deeper view[1] it will appear that the leading idea of a philosophical system emerges from the whole development of the mind, just as it in turn acts back upon that development. The individual thinker finds his principle, so to speak, in the spiritual atmosphere in which he has developed, and separates it out of this atmosphere, just as a chemist separates a substance from its compound with several other substances in order to consider it by itself. Manifold principles that are essential elements in the content of the general consciousness have in this way received their closer treatment and elucidation in different philosophical systems. But philosophy must necessarily come to the insight that it is of the greatest importance to examine how far the principles themselves can be grounded, and how it is possible to reach a true and universally valid principle. English philosophy struck out on this path from the very

[1] See H. Brøchner: Bidrag til Opfattelsen af Filosofiens historiske Udvikling. Kbhvn. 1869.

[6] beginning, and Kant, the greatest philosopher of modern times, has with great profundity shown it to be the only sure path to philosophical knowledge. A philosophy that starts from a principle which is not itself grounded will always come to stand close to theology; there will be a spiritual kinship, however much the philosopher in question asserts the independence of rational knowledge, and however energetically he has emancipated himself from faith in authority. It is above all in method that this kinship between dogmatic or speculative philosophy and theology shows itself. Both proceed deductively and seek to derive their doctrine from one highest principle, which for theology is given by authority and tradition, while in speculative philosophy it is an idea that presents itself to reason with immediate clarity and seems to be self-evident. Critical philosophy is, so to speak, philosophy to the second power. It will not merely philosophize about a given principle, but wants to understand its origin and its justification. It demands, moreover, an account not only of the principle of authority but also of the "self-evident" idea. It sets to work inductively and analytically, insists on getting firm ground under its feet, and recognizes only those principles that follow with necessity from the analysis of the facts of experience.

Spinoza belongs decidedly to the dogmatic-speculative tendency in philosophy. His method is the deductive one. His fundamental concept, the idea of substance, arose for him partly under the influence of the teaching of the popular religion in which he had grown up, partly through the influence of the preceding philosophy. It stood
[7] before him with an inner truth, raised above the need for actual proof. Substance (Dutch: *zelfstandigheid*) is that which is in and of itself, which presupposes nothing whatever else. The idea of substance lies at the basis of the higher popular religions' conception of the Deity as the absolute being, the origin of all things, eternal, imperishable and without limits. But the religious conception, governed by imagination, cannot carry this idea through with full consistency; it always involuntarily places finite existence outside the absolute being, and even ascribes to it the power to hinder, or at least to restrain, its working. In a dim sense of the contradiction in which it thereby entangles itself, the religious conception then seizes upon the dogma of creation as the solution of the riddle: there is indeed something outside the absolute being, with independent reality, but it has come into being through the absolute being's own will and has reality only through it. Spinoza takes up the idea of substance in such a way that he carries

it beyond theological dualism (the doctrine of twoness). But the connection with the religious circle of ideas is seen not only in the fact that in his chief work (the Ethics) he directly designates substance as God, but especially in the whole tone and manner of expression of an earlier work of his ("On God, Man and His Well-Being"), which was found in Amsterdam fifteen years ago. He uses religious conceptions throughout, but gives them a rationalistic application and development. How near he still stands here to the circle of ideas of the Old Testament is seen from an utterance such as this: "True love always springs from the knowledge that its object is glorious and good. Can it then burn more fiercely toward anyone than toward the Lord our God? For he alone is glorious *[8]* and is the perfect good." Spinoza is a religious thinker. The idea of God stands before him with inner clarity and validity, and his whole thought moves within it. But through the further development he gives the idea of God he steps beyond the limits of positive religion, and thereby draws upon himself the charge of irreligion and atheism. He saw clearly that the being which is in and of itself must be the only being and must contain everything within itself, so that there can be no true being outside it. He thus abolished the dualistic opposition between God and the world and rejected the dogma of creation. He is thereby the real founder of monism, or the doctrine of unity. Philosophy, which seeks unity and coherence in everything, must necessarily be monism, and in so far Hegel was right when he said: "Spinoza is so cardinal a point in modern philosophy that one may truly say: either you have Spinozism, or you have no philosophy."

Spinoza is naturally not the first to have put forward monism. Within Greek philosophy he has predecessors in the Eleatics, Plato and Aristotle; but their ideas have hardly had any influence on him. It seems to be otherwise, judging by what can be traced in the treatise just mentioned, with the Jewish and Arabic philosophers of religion of the Middle Ages, in whom a strong pantheistic tendency appears. In the eleventh century there lived in Saragossa a Jewish poet named Ibn-Gebirol, whose religious hymns won great fame. He was the real regenerator of Hebrew poetry, and he holds the first place *[9]* among the Jewish poets of the Middle Ages. But the learned connoisseur of the Jewish and Arabic literature of the Middle Ages, the Frenchman S. Munk, has also shown (see his "Mélanges de philosophie juive et arabe") that Ibn-Gebirol is the same as the author against whom the Christian scholastics polemicized so eagerly under the distorted name Avicebron, and who may be called the classical pantheist of the Middle Ages, as Spinoza

is that of modern times. In his most important work, "The Source of Life" *(fons vitæ)*, he developed—relying on Aristotle and the Neoplatonists—the idea of one form and one matter as revealing themselves in everything, in the spiritual as well as in the corporeal. In the infinite series of beings there is no leap. There is one substance, which subsists by itself and bears all differences, which takes on all forms and gives everything its being and its name. Alongside these pantheistic ideas there runs, to be sure, an attempt to hold fast to the dogma of creation; but "The Source of Life" is nonetheless a purely philosophical work, the only Jewish work from the Middle Ages in which no passages of Scripture or traditions are cited. There is, according to S. Munk, an inner connection between Ibn-Gebirol's poetry and his philosophy: "it is the same circle of thoughts that reveals itself under two different forms, and while one always sees in his poems a mind sunk in deep musings and a stranger to what interests the crowd, his philosophical works often bear traces of the poet's lively imagination and enthusiasm." An Arabic philosopher of the following century, Ibn Roschd (the Averroës of the scholastics, born in Cordova, died
[10] 1198), expresses similar ideas, apparently without knowledge of Ibn-Gebirol's writings. He polemicizes directly against creation out of nothing. Eternal matter contains all the forms within itself. While Muhammadan, Jewish and Christian theologians alike abolish the concept of nature, philosophy asserts a constant transition from possibility to actuality according to the law of eternal necessity. Man thinks by participation in the absolute reason, which is eternal, while every individual thinking being is perishable. True knowledge, which is reached by becoming a participant in the divine reason, is the highest perfection; once it is reached, there is no longer any question of reward and punishment.—A somewhat younger contemporary of Ibn Roschd was the Jewish theologian and philosopher Moses ben Maimon (Maimonides), born in Cordova in 1138, died in Cairo in 1204. He sought to unite faith and knowledge, interpreting the Bible in a rationalistic way, conceiving the religious ceremonies as aids to exercise in true knowledge, and maintaining that scientific insight into God's being is the necessary presupposition of the love of him. His great and remarkable work "The Guide of the Perplexed" (Moreh Nebuchim), which has been translated into French by S. Munk, has had great influence on many eminent minds within Judaism; it was the reading of it that led men like Spinoza, Mendelsohn and Maimon from the synagogue over to philosophy. It is probably through it that Spinoza came to know Ibn Roschd's ideas.—According to

what Grätz states in his "Geschichte der Juden" (vol. 10), there is said to be a certain agreement between some of Spinoza's ideas and expressions and the so-called Kabbalah, *[11]* a fantastic religio-philosophical mysticism that arose within Judaism. Grätz believes in particular that he can demonstrate a similarity between a kabbalistic work by Abraham de Herrera, published in 1656, and several propositions in the first book of Spinoza's "Ethics."

Since we know from Spinoza's biography that he spent his first years of youth studying Jewish theology and philosophy, it is of interest to see what stimulating influences in the direction of his later standpoint he may have received here, directly or indirectly. But these influences were surely only preliminary; he himself declared that it was Descartes's writings that had taught him philosophy. There is a great difference between those medieval speculations and Spinoza's clear and sober thought, which took mathematics as its model.

From the earlier treatise cited above one also sees that Spinoza was influenced by the greatest philosopher of the Renaissance, Giordano Bruno. This restless and fermenting spirit himself points back to Ibn Gebirol and Ibn Roschd, as well as to the Neoplatonists and Aristotle. But apart from these older ideas, which he sought to revive, Giordano Bruno's whole world-view is essentially determined and motivated by Copernicus's discovery of the earth's motion around the sun. He was the enthusiastic prophet of this discovery throughout Europe, and he became its martyr. Through this discovery the old opposition between heaven and earth was effaced, and an infinite horizon opened up, in which Bruno's imagination loved to lose itself. His enthusiasm for nature can still be *[12]* traced in some of Spinoza's utterances. What separates Spinoza from Bruno is not only his strict, systematic thinking, but above all the great advance made in natural science and philosophy in the interval between their appearances. Bruno's conception of nature is poetic and idealistic, and it does not rest on a knowledge of the definite laws of nature and of the real connection of phenomena. But at about the same time that he suffered a martyr's death at the stake of the Inquisition, Galileo made his great discoveries and laid the foundation of modern exact natural science by applying mechanics to astronomy. The mechanical laws of motion, which appear with particular clarity in the motions of the heavenly bodies, now became the foundation of the conception and the explanation of nature. Galileo is the founder of mathematical physics, which rests on the principle

that all physical phenomena can be explained as motions that can be measured either directly or indirectly. Often it is only with the help of experiment that one becomes able to measure; but as soon as this has succeeded, the starting point for mathematical calculation has been won. The goal toward which the mathematical natural science founded by Galileo strives is to derive the facts given in experience with mathematical necessity from as few and as simple presuppositions as possible.

But the path of experimental inquiry is long; for long periods it attains only scattered results and opens only distant prospects of total views and comprehensive standpoints. For many philosophers there has therefore been something unsatisfying about this
[13] method. Only English philosophy at once attached itself—with Bacon, Hobbes and Locke—to the principle and method of experimental inquiry. But it could do so only by provisionally leaving the great speculative problems in abeyance. Where there was a lively need to discuss the questions that lie on the border between religion and philosophy, this method could not yet suffice. English empiricism (the philosophy of experience) was long able to flourish very well with the usual theological conceptions as its background. It was otherwise on the Continent, where philosophy, because of its speculative tendency, at once collided with theology and had to declare itself for or against it. Experimental inquiry acquired only a subordinate significance there; the essential interest is directed toward the development and the carrying through of general ideas. This appears clearly in Spinoza's nearest predecessor, the Frenchman René Descartes.

Descartes was dissatisfied with the scholastic philosophy he had learned at the Jesuit college, and sought a new one with a firmer foundation. He then resolved to disregard all his earlier presuppositions, all the content of knowledge he had previously taken in, and to doubt everything—not in order to become a sceptic, but in order to come to know the nature of human knowledge and to see how far reason can reach by its own powers. Now since doubt is itself a thinking, thinking itself is the only thing of whose reality there can be no doubt, and everything that I see as clearly and distinctly as that I
[14] think must be true. Descartes therefore sets up the rule of truth that made so strong an impression on Spinoza: that clear and distinct conception is the condition of our being able to take anything for true. The first use he makes of this rule is to show that the very concept of doubt leads us to the concept of an absolutely perfect being. For, he says, how could I know that I doubt and that I desire a true knowledge, i.e. that I lack

something and am not wholly perfect, if I did not have the idea of a being more perfect than my own, by comparison with which I can see the defects of my nature? God, or the absolute being, who contains all perfection within himself, therefore becomes the highest principle of philosophy, and true knowledge consists in deriving everything from God's being by clear and distinct inferences. "Since God," says Descartes, "is alone the true cause of everything that is or can be, it is evident that we shall follow the best way of philosophizing if we seek to derive the explanation of created things from God's being." Thus he derives the highest laws of nature from God's immutability, which is one of his perfections, and from the highest laws of nature, or the laws of motion, the special laws. Galileo's procedure is too empirical for Descartes; he reproaches Galileo for not going back to the ultimate grounds. The first of the laws of nature that he derives from God's immutability is precisely the law of inertia, which Galileo had demonstrated by experiment: everything remains, so far as it depends on itself, in the same state, and can never be changed except by external causes.

Descartes will not, like Galileo, go from effects to causes, but conversely, from causes to effects, and the highest cause is given to him immediately in the very nature of thought. *[15]* His method is therefore thoroughly deductive. The facts of experience, by contrast, receive only the significance of guiding thought in a certain definite direction. The model that influences Descartes here is mathematics. He was already thinking of it when he set up clear and distinct knowledge as the mark of truth. Mathematical knowledge stands as a great example of transparent clarity, since in it everything is reduced to relations of magnitude that find their exact determination. Descartes agrees with Galileo that natural science is to be developed mathematically; but he believes that he can explain all special phenomena from the general mathematical laws. He thus makes no distinction between physics and mathematics. "My whole physics," he says in one of his letters, "is nothing but mathematics." Everything that did not have mathematical clarity was for him obscure and confused. He saw the essence of matter in extension. All the other properties of matter can, in his opinion, be thought away, but not extension in length, breadth and height; from it, as the essential, all other properties must therefore be derived. The fundamental properties of matter are divisibility and mobility, and the various material phenomena all arise through the motion of the parts.

It lay all the nearer for Descartes to make the mathematical the main thing in his

conception of the world, since he was himself a mathematician of the first rank; he is the
[16] first who applied algebra to geometry, and thus the founder of analytic geometry and mechanics. And in general it must have lain near for the thinker who wished to set up a new system and a new method in place of medieval scholasticism, with its subtleties of reasoning and its verbal explanations, to seize upon the mathematical method, which is the ideal and the model of all inquiry. There lay in this, moreover, more than a form; there lay a whole program, a prophetic annunciation. The world no longer stands as a play of obscure forces, but as an infinite series of phenomena standing in definite relations to one another, for which clear laws hold. Descartes thus sets up the demand that everything be explained according to necessary laws, a demand whose progressive fulfilment is the natural science of modern times. What Galileo showed in a single domain, Descartes made the principle of the whole conception of the world.

That Descartes makes the transition, with such astonishing speed and ease, from his starting point, the doubt of everything, to the idea of the absolute being, and makes this idea the principle of his doctrine, can be explained only by the influence of religious faith, and we have here a classic example of the peculiarity of the principles of speculative philosophy that was emphasized above. But what must be emphasized here in particular, because it is precisely at this point that Spinoza enters into opposition to Descartes, is that the latter takes up the idea of the absolute being in the same form in which it appears in positive religion. He was himself a believing Catholic, and however energetically he holds fast to the validity and the unrestricted dominion of the laws of nature, he
[17] nevertheless traces them back in the last instance to God's almighty will and explains them by God's immutability. *If* God willed, he could abolish the laws of nature, and even the mathematical laws; 2 and 3 make 5 only because God wills it. And at another point divine intervention becomes positively necessary for Descartes's system. If the essence of matter consists solely in extension, where then is the cause of material motion to be sought? Since it does not lie in the essence of matter, which is purely geometrical, it must lie in God's will. God, says Descartes, set the parts of matter in a certain motion at the creation.

Since Descartes still holds fast to the dogma of creation, he assumes other substances besides the absolute one. God has brought forth mind, the thinking substance, and matter, the extended substance. But here we stand precisely before the contradiction that

philosophizing thought discovers in the religious conception: that on the one hand we have an absolute substance, and yet on the other hand finite substances, brought forth by it. Descartes does remark, to be sure, that he does not take the word substance in the same sense of God and of finite beings; but he does not show how—once he has used it of God—he can have any right at all to use it of finite beings. In this inconsistency lies hidden the problem that was the deepest motive of Spinoza's thought. When Descartes designates both mind and matter as substances, he thereby comes to set them in opposition not only to the absolute substance but also to each other. He gets not only a dualism between the infinite and the finite (God and the world), but also one between mind and matter. With *[18]* respect to both questions he is influenced by theological conceptions. He had clearly seen the difference between the mental (the phenomena of consciousness) and the material, and the impossibility of deriving the one from the other. But this difference became for him a complete opposition, so that he and his school in the end appealed to a miracle to explain the connection of the soul with the body. Here too Spinoza steps in with clear consistency and carries the problem a mighty step further.

Having now briefly brought out the historical conditions under which Spinoza's thought developed, we pass on to an account of his life.

Spinoza's Life

It will already have been seen from the foregoing that Spinoza's doctrine stood in sharp opposition to the religious conceptions that alone prevailed in his time, and when one now recalls how mighty the political and ecclesiastical dominion of authority was in the seventeenth century, it seems a marvel that he was allowed to live as quietly and undisturbed as he did. There was surely no other country than Holland where this would have been possible. Holland is the cradle of religious freedom. In the year 1609 the Dutch had ended their heroic struggle for freedom against mighty Spain,—as a historian has said, the only modern counterpart to the Greeks' struggles for freedom. As the Greeks saved Western culture, so the Dutch saved religious and political freedom. In the manifesto in which they declared themselves free of Spanish rule in 1581, they appealed to "the law of nature,"—a portent of the North Americans' Declaration of Independence and of the Declaration of the Rights of Man in the French Revolution. Freedom in one domain must in the long run bring freedom in all the others with it. *[19]*

Protestantism in its first period was not tolerant, and it also had difficulty in being so, since it was a matter of a struggle of life and death with the Roman Church. Strict discipline had to be kept within the ranks of the combatants. William I of Orange seems to have conceived the religious struggle from a more universal point of view, as a struggle for general religious freedom. But his successors let themselves be guided above all by their aspiration to found a monarchy, and they therefore joined the orthodox clergy, whose influence on the common people thereby also benefited them. Over against the court, the army, the clergy and the common people stood the republican party, which relied chiefly on the wealthy burgher class. In religious respects it joined the so-called Arminians, who contested orthodox Calvinism, asserted freedom of conscience, and allowed everyone to interpret the Bible as he himself wished. While all the other church communities of the *[20]*

time hedged themselves about with a substantial apparatus of "symbolic books," anyone could be a member of the Arminians' congregation who was free of idolatry, offensive conduct and intolerance and acknowledged Scripture as the rule of his life, however he might interpret it. It must be said to their honor that they upheld toleration before they were themselves persecuted. For persecution did not fail to come. The Reformed synod at Dordrecht condemned their doctrine and expelled them from the church community. Maurice of Orange supported the orthodox, who held to him because the republicans and the Arminians wished to restrict the influence of the clergy. Only some time after
[21] Maurice's death were the Arminians allowed to hold divine service. From them again sprang several smaller sects, which followed freer forms in faith and life.

It was no wonder that those who were persecuted for their faith in other countries cast their eyes on Holland and chose it as their refuge. While the Dutch were fighting for freedom, and indeed throughout the whole seventeenth century, the fires of the Inquisition burned merrily in Spain and Portugal. Persecution fell particularly on the Jews who had let themselves be baptized under compulsion, the so-called Marannos, many of whom secretly held fast to their old faith and their old customs. Already during the Dutch war of independence many Marannos had fled to Holland. In 1598 the first synagogue was built in Amsterdam, and two more soon followed. At first they were indeed suspected of being Spanish spies; but once it had been established that this was groundless, and since they also brought large capital with them and gave Amsterdam an impetus forward by their commercial spirit, the authorities showed them great accommodation. The Jewish community grew strongly. In the year 1639 a college for Jewish language and theology was founded, where Spinoza pursued his first studies.

Baruch Spinoza was born on the 24th of November, 1632. The chief source for his biography, the pastor Colerus, who is, however, no reliable witness as regards Spinoza's childhood and youth, relates that he was born in Amsterdam. But Grätz, the learned author of the "Geschichte der Juden," has concluded from a passage in one of Spinoza's letters that he must have been born in Spain and spent his early childhood there. Spinoza
[22] says, namely, that he knew a Jew who was called Judas the Faithful and who suffered a martyr's death at the stake with great heroism. Grätz now informs us that this Judas the Faithful was a Spanish nobleman who was led by zealous study of the Old Testament to the conviction of the truth of Judaism, and who was therefore burned by the Inquisition

in the year 1644. How could Spinoza have known him, if he had not lived in Spain as a child?—Spinoza's parents are called Portuguese Jews; but this was the usual name for all Jews from the Pyrenean peninsula. Either before or, according to Grätz's hypothesis, after the son's birth they had, like so many other Marannos, taken refuge in Holland. The father seems to have been a well-to-do merchant. Because of the boy's good gifts he was destined for the learned profession and attended the Jewish college, where he immersed himself in the study of the Old Testament and the Talmud. He seems also to have made the acquaintance of the Jewish philosophers of religion of the Middle Ages and of kabbalistic mysticism; of one of his teachers, Manasseh ben Israel, it is known that he embraced the kabbalistic doctrines. His keen understanding soon found contradictions in the theological doctrine. He often embarrassed his teachers with his objections and questions. One of his biographers, the physician Lucas, relates that when the rumor of his doubts spread, two of his fellow pupils came to him and pressed him with questions concerning various points of the orthodox doctrine, which Spinoza tried in vain to evade by saying that they had, after all, Moses and the prophets. Later the same *[23]* two persons appeared as witnesses against him and accused him of having mocked Moses and the Jewish people. This caused all the greater stir in the Jewish community because people had thought to see in the gifted young man a future pillar of the synagogue and the college. He had been the favorite of his Talmud teacher Morteira, and only reluctantly did the latter resolve on severe steps against him, especially since Spinoza was very modest and reserved and led a quiet and peaceful life. When Spinoza noticed that he was suspected, he withdrew still further, and his visits to the synagogue became rarer. He now began to associate with Christians and felt the need of a more universal education than the biblical-theological one. He learned Latin, which was then, of course, the common language of learning, and later had as his teacher in the classical languages a physician named van Ende, a well-known humanist, who kept a kind of school for young people in his house. Colerus relates that Spinoza fell in love with his daughter, who helped her father with the teaching, but that she preferred one of his fellow pupils, who better understood the art of gallantry. But this story, on which Auerbach has built a novel, can hardly be true, since it has been established that van Ende's daughter was only twelve years old at the time when Spinoza was excommunicated. Van Ende was very free in his religious views and taught his pupils, as Colerus says, other things

[24] than Latin.[2] Spinoza's doubts and misgivings found their nourishment here. Soon he gave up theology altogether and threw himself into scientific and philosophical studies. "Descartes's writings fell into his hands; he read them with avidity and often declared afterwards that he had drawn his philosophical knowledge from them. He was delighted with Descartes's principle that one must accept nothing as true that has not been proved by good and solid reasons" (Colerus). In Descartes's doctrine he found a world-view that was built throughout on thought and reason. Acquaintance with it completed his emancipation from Jewish theology. His fellow believers harbored the suspicion that he intended to go over to Christianity, and feared that he would become a dangerous adversary of the Jewish religion. It must, as Grätz remarks, have made the rabbis little inclined to tolerance that a multitude of Jews were at the same time suffering martyrdom in Spain. Spinoza, moreover, was not the first example of apostasy from the faith of the fathers in the Amsterdam congregation. Some twenty years before, the synagogue had repeatedly excommunicated Uriel da Costa, a descendant of Marannos, who was led back to Judaism by reading the Old Testament and fled with his family to Amsterdam, where he had himself circumcised, but who, disappointed in his faith in the ideality of Judaism, came out vehemently against the "Pharisees" and was led by continued brooding to deistic views. Da Costa's restless and confused mind led him to no firm standpoint. Despair at being shut out, by the excommunication, from all intercourse with his kinsmen
[25] made him submit to a hard and humiliating penance in order to be received into the synagogue again. But soon afterwards he mocked Judaism anew, was excommunicated again, and in the end killed himself in despair.

With Spinoza, however, they would gladly have avoided an open breach. He was offered a not inconsiderable yearly pension if he would promise not to come out publicly against Judaism and to visit the synagogue now and then. When this offer was not accepted, a fanatic made an attempt to assassinate Spinoza; but he escaped with a few tears in his cloak. At last (1656) they proceeded to the solemn excommunication, which shut him out from intercourse with all his kinsmen. Lucas remarks: "The excommunication has such weight among the Jews that the excommunicated man's best friend does not dare to do him any service or even to speak to him, lest he come to suffer the same punishment.

[2] Van Ende later settled in Paris, and was hanged there as a Dutch spy and an accomplice in the Chevalier de Rohan's conspiracy.

Therefore those who fear solitude would rather suffer any other punishment whatever than the curse." Spinoza had early learned to value solitude, and through his studies and his whole spiritual development he had, moreover, been initiated into a more universal world and had gained a larger spiritual fatherland. When he learned that they meant to expel him, he is said to have said: "They are not forcing me here to anything I would not have done of my own accord. Since they will now have it so, I take the path that opens before me, and I can console myself that I go away more innocent than the ancient Hebrews went out of Egypt, although my livelihood is no more assured than theirs." But the rabbis were not content with the excommunication. They informed the authorities *[26]* that Spinoza had blasphemed God and Moses, and demanded that he be removed from Amsterdam. Perhaps they feared that Spinoza would draw others after him; the formula of excommunication itself mentions that he has led some astray, and there are also, as we shall soon hear, other traces of his having had disciples already at this time. When the Reformed clergy joined their Jewish colleagues, Spinoza was banished from the city for a time "for the maintenance of order and subordination." A Spanish apology that he is said to have written on this occasion has not been preserved; presumably he set out in it the views on religious freedom that he later developed at length in his "Theologico-Political Treatise." He took up residence with a friend in the country outside Amsterdam. It now stood him in good stead that he had in his time, following the precept the Talmud gives to all the learned, learned a craft, namely the grinding of optical lenses. By this work he earned what he needed for his living.

The oldest work we have from Spinoza's hand must have been written shortly after his expulsion from the synagogue. It is the treatise "On God, Man and His Well-Being," originally written in Latin, which was found fifteen years ago in a Dutch translation. It is of great interest in showing us Spinoza's view in the making. He has corrected Cartesianism with the recognition that, when the concept of substance is conceived consistently, there can be only one substance, whose forms of manifestation all things are. His peculiar deterministic conception likewise appears clearly and definitely; everything, the human will included, follows the law of necessity. But he still holds the Cartesian *[27]* conception of the relation between soul and body, which he lets act upon each other. Finally, he uses religious conceptions and expressions throughout, and assumes final causes in nature. This last is of particular interest, since it points decidedly to other

predecessors than Descartes,—to the thinkers of the Middle Ages and the Renaissance.[3] Neither Descartes nor Spinoza's later doctrine ascribes validity to final causes in the conception of nature; both maintain the strict mechanical mode of explanation at every point.

In the preface to the Dutch translation of this treatise it is said that it had been written down in its time by Spinoza for the use of his disciples, who wished to pursue the study of ethics and philosophy.—The treatise itself ends with these words: "I ask the friends for whom I have written this not to wonder at what is new in it, since you well know that a thing does not cease to be true because it is not accepted by many. And since the character of the age in which we live is not unknown to you, I beg you earnestly to be very careful about acquainting others with these things. I will not say that you are to keep them entirely to yourselves, but only that, if you ever begin to communicate them to others, no other aim may move you than the good of your fellow men."

In the year 1661 Spinoza (who after his expulsion from the synagogue had exchanged
[28] his Hebrew name Baruch for the Latin Benedictus, which means the same) moved to Rhynsburg, a small town near Leyden. Here, during the Arminian persecution, a small free congregation had formed, which would have nothing to do with priests or creeds, but required only, quite in general, a faith in God and Christ; they were called Collegiants or Rhynsburgers, and they still existed at the beginning of this century. Spinoza seems to have been on a friendly footing with them, as well as with the so-called Mennonites (Anabaptists). It was in the Collegiants' former orphanage that several hitherto unknown letters from and to Spinoza were found some years ago. Spinoza never went over to Christianity, but he seems to have sympathized above all with the freer, half rationalistic forms in which he found it among the Arminians and Collegiants.

In his rural abode he continued his studies with zeal, and one sees from his letters that his system was finished in all its characteristic fundamental features at the beginning of his stay in Rhynsburg. He remained in touch with the circle of younger men that had already formed around him in Amsterdam, and that made up a kind of philosophical congregation, striving to live their way into the new view of life. Strangely enough, the first editor of Spinoza's letters struck out of them every allusion to this circle of adherents; no doubt because it was not advisable then, immediately after Spinoza's death, to draw

[3] See above, pp. 8–11.

attention to it. From the manuscripts found in the Collegiants' orphanage, on the other hand, we receive information about it. One of Spinoza's younger friends, Simon de Vries, *[29]* who on his advice was studying chemistry and medicine in Amsterdam, writes to him to get enlightenment on some difficult points in a manuscript Spinoza had entrusted to him, which was probably the draft of the "Ethics." But while in the original edition of the letters he makes this inquiry in his own name, in the original manuscript that was found he speaks on behalf of several. "I have," he says, "long wished to visit you, but my time and the hard winter have not allowed it. I lament my fate that we are now separated by so great a distance. How happy is your housemate, who can talk with you of the highest things at meals and on walks. But although we are physically far from each other, you are nevertheless always present to my mind, especially when I am busy with your writings. Now since not everything in them is clear enough to my companions—for which reason we have begun our college again,—and also so that you will not think I have forgotten you, I write you this letter. Our college is arranged in the following way. One of us reads aloud (each in his turn), explains everything as he has understood it, and proves it following the order of your propositions. Now when we cannot agree on the understanding of one point or another, we note it down and write to you about it, so that you may explain it to us, and so that under your guidance we may defend the truth against the superstitiously pious and Christian, and stand firm against the whole world."

The first work of Spinoza's to be printed was a systematic exposition of Descartes's philosophy, which he had given to a young man who wanted to be taught by him, and *[30]* whom he did not yet wish to initiate into his own doctrine. It was published in 1663 by his friend, the physician Ludvig Meyer, under the title *Renati des Cartes Principia philosophiæ more geometrico demonstrata.* Meyer remarks in the preface that the work must not be regarded as an expression of the author's own views, and names, as points in which these differ from Descartes's, the questions of the freedom of the will, of the human soul as a substance of its own, and of the limits of knowledge. As to the last point, Descartes had declared, in favor of theology, that there was much that surpassed the human power of comprehension. Spinoza, on the contrary, believed that the problems at which Descartes had stopped could indeed be solved if one only applied the right procedure. In an appendix, *Cogitata metaphysica*, he indicates somewhat more closely the transition from Descartes's views to his own.

Besides the circle of younger men in Amsterdam with whom Spinoza remained constantly in touch, he had many correspondents and received many visits. His time was heavily occupied, since besides the lens grinding, which was his source of livelihood, he continued his studies and busied himself with chemical and physical experiments. It was perhaps in order to be less disturbed that in the year 1664 he left Rhynsburg[4] and
[31] settled in Voorburg, a mile from The Hague. But since he had gained many friends in The Hague, he moved to that city in the year 1669 at their urging, and lived there for the rest of his life. First he lodged with a widow, later with the painter van der Spijk. Most of his time he spent in his room at his work. He diverted himself by catching flies and putting them into spiders' webs, or by setting spiders to fight, a sight at which he could sometimes burst into peals of laughter. He also often examined insects, or particular parts of them, under a microscope. He was a skilled draftsman, and a whole collection of portraits he had made was found after his death; among them one of himself in the dress of Masaniello.[5] He often went down to his landlord's family and talked with them about everything under the sun, especially when there was sickness or sorrow in the house. His way of life was frugal in the highest degree, and his wants were few. The pastor Colerus cites several details in this respect in his biography, from the bills that were found after his death. Neither pleasures nor money played any part for him. He showed great unselfishness toward his sisters, although they had tried to exclude him from his paternal inheritance. After he had had his right of inheritance recognized by a
[32] lawsuit, he left them almost the whole inheritance. His friend Simon de Vries wanted to give him a sum of money so that he could live more comfortably; but he declined it, just as he also opposed de Vries's making him his universal heir; a pension that de Vries had settled on him at his death he accepted only after having reduced it considerably.

In the year 1670 he published his *Tractatus theologo-politicus*, in which he examined the relation of religion to philosophy and showed the necessity of religious freedom. This work is the first proclamation of unconditional freedom of belief. During the struggles between Catholics and Protestants in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries

[4]The little house in which he lived in Rhynsburg still stands, and the street is sometimes called Spinoza Street. On the house there is the following inscription from the year 1667: Ach, waren alle menschen wijs, En wilden darby wel: De aard waar haar een Paradijs, Nu is ze meest een Hel. The first three lines could agree with Spinoza's thoughts; the fourth is wholly at odds with his optimistic conception.

[5]The portrait from which the vignette of this volume is taken was painted by Spinoza's landlord van der Spijk. There is great dissimilarity between the various portraits of Spinoza that exist.

the vanquished had no doubt often pleaded the cause of toleration, but always with great restrictions. Spinoza asserts the right to express one's conviction as a human right of which the state cannot deprive the individual, so long as he does not encroach upon the rights of others. The spiritual nature of men is so various that they cannot all feel satisfied with the same opinions. Spinoza shows, further, that there is a religiousness independent of dogmas and ceremonies; he applies a historical criticism to the biblical books, by which he became the forerunner of the whole of modern biblical criticism; and he seeks to give a psychological and historical explanation of the spiritual state of the prophets. Since he showed, moreover, how dangerous it is when the clergy have too great an influence in the state, it is no wonder that a great stir arose over the anonymous book. By bold utterances that made God's power coincide with nature's, he also gave offense to those who had no love for the hierarchy. Several of his correspondents grew *[33]* cooler from this time. The book was banned, but soon appeared again under other titles.

Spinoza's position was not without danger, although he sought to live as inconspicuously as possible. He had in a way challenged by his book the mighty party of Orange and of the clergy, which had the common people on its side. He was, moreover, a friend of the famous statesman Jan de Witt, who stood at the head of the republican party, and against whom the preachers stirred up the people in their sermons. The disasters of the French war brought de Witt down, and the mob, which regarded him as a traitor, tore him and his brother to pieces in the most horrible manner. At about the same time the great Condé, who was in command at Utrecht, wished to speak with the famous philosopher and sent him a safe-conduct. At the wish of his friends Spinoza accepted the invitation; but when he arrived, Condé had suddenly been called away. The Marshal of Luxembourg, however, received him with great attention. It was suggested to him that he dedicate a work to Louis XIV, who would then give him a yearly pension; but Spinoza would not hear of it. When he came back to The Hague, people crowded together outside his lodging in a threatening manner, because the rumor went about that he was in treasonable communication with the enemy. His landlord was frightened at this; but Spinoza calmed him and declared that "as soon as the crowd made a move to attack the house, he would go out to them, even if he should suffer the same fate as the poor *[34]* brothers de Witt; he knew in his own heart that he was a good republican, who had never had anything in view but the honor and the advantage of the state."

Not only in France, but also in Germany, attention had been drawn to Spinoza. In the year 1673 he received from the Elector Palatine, Karl Ludwig, known for his interest in learning, through Professor Fabritius, an invitation to take up a professorship of philosophy at Heidelberg. He was promised the greatest freedom to philosophize, so long as he did not offend the religion established in the state. But Spinoza did not accept the invitation. "In the first place," he wrote in his reply, "I should not be able to carry philosophy further if my time were taken up with teaching. In the second place, I do not know where the limits of the freedom to philosophize that you mention lie, so that I might not appear to wish to offend the established religion. Religious quarrels arise not so much from burning religious zeal as from the various passions of men and their love of contradiction, which leads them to disparage and condemn everything, even what is right. And since I have already experienced this in the private and solitary life I now lead, I must fear it all the more if I accept such a dignity." Spinoza had good reason to be wary of appearing as a public teacher of philosophy; he would hardly have been able to put forward one or two of his doctrines before the state religion would have been regarded
[35] as offended. At that time, in spite of all fine promises, there could be no question of real freedom of teaching.[6]—It seems as though the Elector knew Spinoza only as the author of the work on Descartes's philosophy, not as the author of the Theologico-Political Treatise. Even so, it was a sign of liberality to wish to appoint an excommunicated Jew who had not gone over to Christianity.

Spinoza himself did not regard his relation to the popular religion as a hostile one. True religiousness did not, in his conviction, depend on any confession of faith whatever. Those who could not reach the knowledge of the divine by way of thought must find their rest in the doctrines of a positive religion. He liked to talk with his landlord and his family when they had been to church, and to ask them what profit they had had from it. In Voorburg he joined in signing a petition concerning the filling of a pastorate, and in The Hague he several times heard his landlord's pastor, whom he praised highly. When

[6]Even in our own day it has been declared among us that a university teacher may not attack the doctrines of the state church. One of our newspapers held that the late Professor Brøchner had misunderstood his position in this respect. But a public teacher of a science surely cannot reasonably be bound by other laws than those that lie in the very nature of the science; they will surely contain every needful guarantee. It must be precisely his highest duty to separate out of the kingdom of truth everything that has unwarrantably crept into it. The life of the state and of the people would in the end languish if certain doctrines were given the privilege of being exceptions to this rule.

his landlady asked him whether he thought she could be saved in the religion to which she belonged, he answered: "Your religion is good, and you should not seek any other *[36]* or doubt that it will lead you to salvation, if only you apply yourself to piety and lead a peaceful and quiet life." He saw far too clearly how much it takes to form a view of life for oneself, once one has left the inherited one, to lead away from it anyone who could not yet stand on his own feet. But he naturally also saw how much the inherited doctrines can hinder progress in the knowledge of truth, since human sloth is glad to rest content with what has been instilled in it as a child. The greatest misfortune they cause, however, is by the strife and contention they occasion; it is the various opinions received through tradition that divide men, whereas by following nature they would reach agreement, as children of one and the same mother.

Just as Colerus emphasizes his respect for the faith of others, another theologian too, Sebastian Kortholt, who some twenty years after Spinoza's death collected information about him, and who otherwise condemns him in very fanatical terms, says that "no oath and no impudent speech about God was ever heard from Spinoza's mouth." On the other hand, the Reformed theologian Limborch relates that he—quite unexpectedly—met Spinoza at a dinner, and that during the grace at table the latter showed his ungodly disposition, "in that by his expression he seemed to mock the stupidity of those praying." This account is wholly at odds with what is otherwise known of Spinoza's character and conduct, and it is surely only a testimony to how disposed Limborch was to find "signs of ungodliness" *(signa animi irreligiosi)* in the freethinker in whose company he *[37]* had—very much against his will—found himself. The good theologian, moreover, as has rightly been remarked, cannot have been very absorbed in his prayer if he sat watching Spinoza's face.

Spinoza's conversation is said to have been witty and lively, and it held a great attraction for many. His great acuteness and fine irony made what he said both instructive and entertaining. His bearing always showed the stamp of mildness and self-control; he was never seen either much saddened or overjoyed, and when feeling became too strong he would rather withdraw than give it vent before others. In the last part of his life his health was greatly weakened; he suffered from a wasting disease of the chest, which his strenuous studies had nourished and perhaps brought on. In this sickliness one may perhaps seek the reason for his small productivity toward the end of his life.

The "Ethics" seems to have been finished already in the sixties, and in those years he was also working on the "Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect," which was found unfinished after his death. In the year 1675 he gave in to the requests of his friends and traveled to Amsterdam to have the Ethics printed. But the rumor at once spread that he meant to publish a book that would prove there was no God. The theologians complained of him at court and to the authorities, and the Cartesians, who were regarded as his kindred spirits, joined in, in order to clear themselves of all complicity. Spinoza therefore decided to postpone the publication to better times; but he did not live to see them. Only
[38] after his death did Ludvig Meyer publish the Ethics, an unfinished political treatise, the unfinished Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, an unfinished Hebrew grammar, and a collection of letters.

The "Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect" is of interest, among other things, because we see from it how Spinoza's thought springs in its last ground from an ethical motive. He begins this work in the following way: "After experience had taught me that everything we meet with in ordinary life is vain and futile, and since I saw that there is nothing good or bad in the things we most fear, except in so far as the mind is moved by them, I resolved to inquire whether there is anything that is a true good, that can communicate its being to us, and that can affect the soul by itself, even if all other goods are rejected; in other words, whether there is anything by whose acquisition and possession I could enjoy a lasting, eternal and supreme happiness." In contrast to the false and perishable goods, the knowledge of the eternal and of our unity with it, or the knowledge of our mind's connection with the whole of nature, is then set up as the true and highest good. To reach this goal we must gain a true knowledge of the nature of things and strive that as many as possible share it with us. A purification and reformation of knowledge must therefore be undertaken, and a community formed in which as many as possible can be brought up and developed toward the goal indicated.

In his chief work, the "Ethics" *(Ethica ordine geometrico demonstrata)*, Spinoza carried
[39] through the mathematical method he had already applied in his exposition of Descartes's doctrine, a method that can be used only in a very forced way in treating metaphysical, psychological and ethical questions. The way in which Spinoza applies this method, however, not only testifies to his great acuteness, but also brings clarity and transparency into the course of thought, something in which other speculative methods are otherwise

sorely lacking. Spinoza gives, moreover, in the prefaces and appendices to the individual books and in the remarks (scholia) to the individual propositions, connected developments that in part touch on what is most interesting in the book, and to which one should chiefly keep at a first reading.[7] The "Ethics" is divided into 5 books. The first (de deo) treats of God as the absolute substance, of his attributes and of the relation of things to him, and thus gives the fundamental features of Spinoza's general world-view. The second book *(de natura et origine mentis)* treats of the nature of man, his relation to God and to other finite beings, in particular of the relation between mind and matter and of human knowledge. The third book *(de origine et natura affectuum)* treats of the nature and origin of the passions and gives a masterly psychological portrayal of them. In the fourth book *(de servitute humana s. de affectuum viribus)* it is shown what dominion the passions can gain over man. It is the portrayal of man in his state of bondage, which gradually passes over into freedom, as his true nature develops. Finally, the fifth book *(de* *[40]*
potentia intellectus s. de libertate humana) portrays man in the eternal reality of his ideal being. Thus this magnificent work gives us, in Herbart's apt comparison, the picture of a drama in five acts. It has exposition, complication and the untying of the knot. First come God and the human mind; then follows what weighs the mind down, the affects, and the portrayal of human bondage; finally spiritual freedom.

To the "Ethics" is joined the "Political Treatise," on which Spinoza was working when he died. Two things, after all, were presupposed for the realization of the highest good: true knowledge, which the "Ethics" shows us in its application to man's relation to the passions, and the right community, whose nature is set forth in the "Political Treatise," which examines natural right, the power of the state, and the origin and end of society.

But it is not only by his profound and liberal writings that Spinoza has worked for the cause of philosophy and of free inquiry. His whole life, whose purity and ideal direction even his opponents had to acknowledge, has been an important argument in the dispute between philosophy and theology. It lay in the spirit of those times to regard it as an impossibility that a man who placed himself outside positive religion could be a good man and lead a moral life. Spinoza's life therefore became a theological problem. The first who, after Spinoza himself, declared with energy that the good and the right have their

[7] Besides in Latin, one can now also read Spinoza in two German translations (by Auerbach and by Kirchmann) and in an excellent French translation (by Saisset).

sanction in themselves and do not depend on the commands of authority was Pierre Bayle.
[41] He pointed in particular precisely to Spinoza (whose true significance he otherwise failed to see) as proof of the proposition that morality does not depend on positive religion. In our literature Holberg and Eilskov were influenced by Bayle's ideas; they emphasize, however, above all another proposition of his, namely that it is natural disposition and temperament rather than articles of faith that determine men's conduct. Eilskov holds that when freethinkers do not live ungodly lives, it must be explained by the fact "that they have followed the nature of their disposition more than the laws of virtue; they have lived so more because they found in themselves no natural impulse to live otherwise than from fear that they would otherwise transgress their duties. That is without doubt the reason for Spinoza's quiet and honorable way of life." By this conception, as Holberg says, "the whole disputation became futile" (Ep. 210), that is, the question was disposed of by the recognition that character and conduct are relatively independent of theories and views, in believers and unbelievers alike. It would also be wrong to think of Spinoza as a saint; in him, as in everyone else, the moral character was surely determined by his original temperament, and not without reason has his disease of the chest also been pointed to as an explanation of his reserved, resigned way of life. Perhaps one may also reproach him with a certain passivity; his enthusiasm was in any case of the quiet kind, resting in itself, and it did not lead him—like a Giordano Bruno or a J. G. Fichte—to offer open defiance to his age in the struggle for his ideas. But what is great and beautiful in
[42] his character is, on the other hand, precisely the harmony between his personality and his doctrine; for in the faith in the eternal ground of nature that stirs in everything and in all lies also the assurance that the true is eternally victorious. And his life always keeps the significance that by its testimony it has helped to set irrelevant moral considerations aside in the discussion of philosophical and scientific questions.

If in those times it was a question whether a freethinker could live a moral life, it was subject to still greater doubt whether he could die in peace. Many different rumors were therefore in circulation concerning Spinoza's death. Some claimed to know that he had stupefied himself with mandrake juice when he felt death approaching, others that he had uttered cries of despair and forbidden his landlady to let any pastor near him, so that no one should witness his weakness. Fortunately two theologians undertook, shortly after Spinoza's death, to inquire into the truth of these rumors, and both of these

"unwilling" witnesses declare them wholly groundless. Spinoza's landlord and landlady were still living and could relate everything that was known of his death. His weakness of the chest had steadily increased; but neither he himself nor those around him expected that he would die so soon. The day before, he had been downstairs with his landlord and smoked a pipe while talking with him about the day's sermon, and even on the morning of the day he died (the 21st of February, 1677) he was likewise downstairs with his landlord and his family. All the more astonished were they, when they came home from church in the afternoon, to hear that he had died at three o'clock. No one had been *[43]* with him except his friend, the physician Ludvig Meyer of Amsterdam, who left again the same evening. One of our two authorities, Seb. Kortholt, says expressly that he "breathed his last sigh in peace," although he adds that the learned have disagreed as to whether such a death befitted an atheist. And Colerus refutes all the rumors, although shortly afterwards he is scandalized that Spinoza is called "the *late blessed* Mr. Spinoza" in bills that came in to the estate. But although Colerus regarded Spinoza as damned in the other world, the history of philosophy must nevertheless be very grateful to the worthy pastor for having striven so eagerly in his biography, which in all its naïveté is an interesting little book, to clear his memory in this present world. It is also a reconciling feature that Spinoza, the advocate of resignation and toleration, found a truth-loving and impartial biographer in the camp of his opponents.

Spinoza and His Correspondents

Before we pass on to a connected account of Spinoza's philosophical doctrine, it will be *[44]* of interest to dwell on his correspondence. His ideas appear in it in part in a somewhat freer form than in his writings, and thereby become more easily accessible. It also serves to characterize his historical position to see how his nearest contemporaries received his ideas. An account of the relation between Spinoza and his correspondents thus forms a fitting transition between the biography and the system.

In the Introduction we brought out the opposition between empirical inquiry into detail and speculative, deductive thought. This opposition comes out in an interesting way in the letters exchanged between him and his friend Henry Oldenburg.

Oldenburg was born in Bremen and was, under Cromwell and Charles II, the envoy of the Lower Saxon Circle in London. He took a great interest in physical and chemical experiments, was the first secretary of the Royal Society, founded in 1662, and a good friend of the famous Boyle, the founder of analytical chemistry.

Oldenburg was no great mind, but he was enthusiastic about his acquaintance with *[45]* Spinoza, whom he visited in Rhynsburg, and about the vigorous upswing that experimental inquiry was taking in England at that time. He took pleasure in being the go-between for his two brilliant friends, but he is not free of adorning himself with his relation to them. Through him a discussion was carried on between them, prompted by a work of Boyle's that had been sent to Spinoza. Spinoza objected to Boyle's wishing to conclude from his experiments that the difference between the properties of bodies could be traced back to differences in motion, figure and other mechanical relations. Spinoza holds, like Descartes, that everything in nature must be explained according to the laws of mechanism, but denies that the justification of this mode of explanation can be established by experiment. The proof that can be in question here he regards as given by Descartes and

Bacon. If all phenomena in nature presuppose motion, and motion in turn extension in space, then the essence of matter is one with extension, and the laws of extension, the propositions of geometry, thus become the real laws of nature, to which everything must be traced back. Spinoza lacked an eye for the significance of inductive inquiry. What he sought was the essence of things, expressed in clear concepts. But experience does not teach us, as he says in another of his letters, the necessary essence of things, but only what actually exists. What truly is, for Spinoza, was not the particular things and phenomena, but the general laws and the infinite being that lies at the basis of everything.
[46] Experience can have only the significance of guiding our thoughts in certain definite directions, but it cannot give us a true knowledge. Boyle, on the other hand, aimed precisely at the investigation of the particular and special, and left the inner essence of things alone. He collected observations and analyzed the particular substances, but he did not aspire to set up any theory. It was also precisely careful observation that chemistry needed in order to get beyond alchemy, and it owes much to Boyle's sceptical-empirical spirit. Even a layman can still read with interest and profit his "*Sceptical Chymist*" and the other treatises in which he combats peripatetic and alchemical chemistry. Oldenburg urges his friends each to use his own method with zeal. "You," he writes to Spinoza, "I ask in particular to go on laying the principles of things with your mathematical acuteness, just as I constantly urge my noble friend Boyle to confirm and illuminate science by repeated and exact experiments and observations." This was in reality the best solution of such a dispute. Neither of the two methods can be dispensed with; what matters is that each find its proper domain and its true limits.

Oldenburg was not so fortunate in another discussion with Spinoza. It appeared here, as was touched on in the Introduction, that the purely empirical urge to inquire can be very limited; in the particular domain one has chosen, one seeks clear grounds and proofs, but one can for all that follow, in one's view of life, the first tradition that comes along and take reason captive. Oldenburg wrote his first letter to Spinoza shortly
[47] after his visit to Rhynsburg. He had felt so drawn to Spinoza that he at once felt the need to enter into communication with him, especially since much of what they had talked about was not yet clear to him. What he particularly balked at was Spinoza's conception of God as the infinite substance, whose forms of expression all things are. Since Oldenburg always starts from the usual theological conceptions, it is no wonder

that he does not understand Spinoza. It seems as though the latter sees this and is glad to seize on the chemical exchange he entered into with Boyle through Oldenburg, in order to end the fruitless discussion. Yet at this stage Oldenburg appears as the eager and enthusiastic friend of free inquiry. He urges Spinoza to publish his writings and to speak his mind in spite of the theologians' yapping *(qvicqvid theologastri ogganire poterint).* "Your republic," he writes, "enjoys, after all, a very great freedom. One should therefore also philosophize in it with freedom. Put away all fear of stirring up the petty men of our time! Long enough have ignorance and quackery had free play: let us now hoist the flag of true science and search out the secrets of nature still more deeply than before!" This zeal, however, was somewhat cooled by closer acquaintance with Spinoza's doctrine, and above all by the "Theologico-Political Treatise" and the great offense it gave. Both Oldenburg's and Boyle's views were orthodox. Another of Spinoza's correspondents, the physicist and philosopher Tschirnhausen, who was staying in London at this time, found that Boyle and Oldenburg had formed "strange notions" of Spinoza's person; he succeeded, however, in ridding them of these prejudices, so that they again came to think favorably of him. After an interruption of some ten years the correspondence is *[48]* resumed, and Oldenburg begins by declaring that he had held an unfavorable opinion of Spinoza because he had applied to his views the measure "that the usual theologians and the inherited confessions of faith supply"; now, on the contrary, he has seen that it was a hasty judgment. He wishes to be initiated more closely into Spinoza's doctrine, and offers his help in gaining it entry among sensible and good men and in defending it against prejudice. But when he hears that Spinoza means to publish his Ethics, he earnestly admonishes him not to say anything that could in any way seem to shake piety and virtue—"especially since this degenerate and wicked age seeks nothing more eagerly than doctrines that can defend the prevailing vices." Spinoza asks for a closer explanation of what doctrines these are that could offend piety and virtue; for what agrees with reason he also holds to be most serviceable to virtue. Oldenburg then names three points. Spinoza seems to confuse God and nature. He abolishes the truth and validity of miracles, and it is on them, after all, that the certainty of revelation rests. Finally, his opinion of the person of Christ is unclear. If only he can satisfy all true Christians on these points, his cause will be out of danger. Spinoza answers roughly as follows. 1) I conceive God as an indwelling (immanent) cause; he does not act beyond the limits of his being, for his

being is infinite and has nothing outside itself. The apostle Paul, after all, also says that in God we live and move and have our being. And when I am accused of confusing God
[49] and nature, nature is taken to mean the outward mass, corporeal matter, and I am wholly misunderstood. 2) To found revelation on miracles is to found it on ignorance. No one knows what the powers of nature can accomplish, and because we cannot find the natural causes in a particular case, we are not entitled to deny their existence. Religion ought to be judged by the truth of its teaching; otherwise it does not differ from superstition, which builds on ignorance. 3) It is not necessary to know Christ after the flesh; what matters is to partake of the eternal Son of God, that is, the eternal, divine wisdom that has revealed itself in all things, most in the human mind, and most of all in Christ. But the teaching of some churches that God has taken on human nature I do not understand; to me it is as absurd as saying that the circle has taken on the nature of the square.—On this last point Spinoza is a forerunner of the modern speculative philosophy of religion, and he has in particular expressed a thought that Strauss developed further in the concluding treatise of his famous "Leben Jesu."—Oldenburg now at last comes out with the real chief objection: that Spinoza teaches an eternal necessity in all things, from which it must follow that no one is responsible for his actions. Spinoza answers that the necessary connection in all things is precisely the foundation of his whole doctrine. But, he says, I do not teach fatalism; the necessity that is the expression of a being's own nature is one with true freedom; it is not an outward but an inward necessity, and it does not abolish the difference between good and evil.

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It was Spinoza's distinction and his greatness that he did not want thought only up to a certain point, that he did not stop halfway. His striving for a coherent scientific world-view was fully justified, even if he cherished illusions about the power of speculative thought. A philosophical problem, once it has been posed, cannot be pushed back out of regard for any other presuppositions whatever. But many speak with apparent recognition of reason and thought, and when it then becomes serious, when the honesty of the recognition is to show itself in one's bowing to the result, they jump off, like soldiers who get cannon fever. It can be a long and laborious way for the individual before he brings harmony between his feelings and interests and the clear truth that knowledge shows him. But the way must and shall be traveled, sooner or later. Along this way the race goes forward, just as the individual goes forward along it in quiet.—Oldenburg was one of those who

turn back when the bullets begin to whistle. And in him this stands out all the more, since he began by being so bold about it and came forward as the enthusiastic man of progress.

One feels more sympathy in this respect with another of Spinoza's correspondents, although it went with him in a similar way. A merchant from Dordrecht, Willem van Bleyenbergh, occupied himself in his leisure hours with philosophical studies and had read Spinoza's exposition of Descartes's philosophy several times. He now writes to Spinoza and presents himself as a man who is guided by a need for pure and genuine truth and seeks to satisfy this need through science. But he, like Oldenburg, is repelled *[51]* by Spinoza's determinism. If God acts in everything, he says, then it is God, after all, who acts in Adam's sin too, and so either God himself must be evil, or sin must not be anything real and positive.—Spinoza meets him with great kindness. "Nothing," he says, "do I value more than to enter into friendship with men who sincerely love truth. Such a friendship is founded on the love that each of them has for the knowledge of truth, and therefore one can no more dissolve it than one can refrain from embracing the truth one has once recognized. Nothing but truth can bring about a deep bond between different dispositions and characters." With respect to the question Bleyenbergh had raised, Spinoza declares that concepts such as good and evil arise and are applied when we compare actions and events with one another by a certain standard. But our relative concepts cannot be applied to the absolute being. God can no more be characterized by concepts taken from human nature than a man by concepts taken from the nature of the elephant. (In another letter Spinoza says that if the triangle could speak, it would say that God was "triangular in an eminent sense"—*eminenter triangularis,*—and the circle, that he was "circular in an eminent sense"—*eminenter circularis.)* We therefore may not ascribe hatred or anger to God either, as the theologians do, and as Scripture seems to do, since it accommodates itself to the conception of the common people, for whom God stands as lawgiver and judge and not as the eternal and infinite being that dwells in everything *[52]* and from which everything springs. Because everything happens with necessity, the difference between the good and the wicked is not effaced, any more than the difference between joy and sorrow. The good man lives in the clear consciousness of his harmony with the idea of God, which determines all his actions, while the consciousness of the evil man is filled with finite and earthly things.—Bleyenbergh now explains his standpoint

more closely. He has two rules by which he philosophizes: the one is the clear and evident conception of his understanding, the other God's revealed word and will. Even if something stands before him as clear and evident, he nevertheless holds that he is mistaken if it conflicts with Scripture. Spinoza replies to this that the Bible can teach us nothing whatever in philosophical respects. What it teaches is, when one applies a philosophical measure, often wholly incomprehensible, whereas one can never doubt the truth of what is proved clearly and distinctly. But what is the use of discussing when one party expressly declares that a proof makes an impression on him only so far as it agrees with what Scripture—according to his own or some theologians' interpretation—teaches, and that rational knowledge is therefore, properly speaking, a matter of indifference to him?—A visit Bleyenbergh paid to Spinoza in Voorburg brought no closer understanding about, and Spinoza at last broke off the correspondence in a friendly way and referred him to oral discussion. Bleyenbergh later published polemical writings against Spinoza's works.

We cannot here inquire more closely with what right the charge was constantly
[53] brought against Spinoza that his doctrine of necessity (determinism) abolishes all freedom and morality. In the last chapter of my work "Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik" I have treated the questions that belong here at greater length. The difficulty there may be here does not in any case stem from determinism in itself, but from the speculative conception that lies at its basis. And this difficulty is, as Spinoza's critics always overlook, common to pantheism and theism. Whether one assumes an eternal substance that stirs in everything or an almighty will that creates everything, it becomes equally difficult to understand how a finite being can possess an absolutely free will. Consistent theologians like Augustine (and after him Descartes and Leibnitz) therefore answer the question in a similar way to Spinoza. The difference is only that theology places the difficulty a stretch further back, as philosophical difficulties in general tend to recur in theology at higher powers. The difficulty has in this case arisen from the deductive method, which is, after all, common to theology and speculative philosophy. If we apply the inductive method to psychological and ethical questions, on the other hand, everyone admits that we understand an action only when we can trace it back to the individual's character, previous history and circumstances of life. There can in principle be nothing in human actions that could not be explained in this way if all the circumstances were known to us.

Determinism is therefore unconditionally right and is involuntarily applied in practice by each and every one. But it does not follow that we are reduced to letting ourselves be carried along by the stream. We stand toward our own mental and bodily nature as *[54]* toward outward nature: if we can make ourselves masters of the conditions, we can also determine the course of things, divert or restrain the stream; but whether we can do so, only experience can decide in each particular case. Miracles we can work neither in inner nor in outer nature.—This way of regarding the matter is, moreover, as we shall see later, not foreign to Spinoza, although the deductive method is the one that governs his views.

Spinoza stood in friendly relations with Orobio de Castro, a Spanish Jew, who after frightful tortures in the prisons of the Inquisition had fled to Holland and there gone over to the religion of his fathers. He did not share Spinoza's views and later wrote against him. He sent Spinoza a letter in which Lambert van Welthuysen of Utrecht, an adherent of the Cartesian philosophy, gives his opinion of Spinoza's "Theologico-Political Treatise." It is remarkable, but not unique, that Welthuysen, who in his writings shows himself a rationalist and was accused by the theologians of Socinianism, speaks of Spinoza's doctrine with far greater vehemence than the orthodox Oldenburg and Bleyenbergh. The author of the work in question, says Welthuysen, has put off all religion; at the least he goes further than the deists, with whom these ungodly times swarm, and teaches atheism covertly (*clam*), in that he lets the universe spring with necessity from God, which is the same as making God one with the world, and in that he teaches that the worship of God is only to serve to promote virtue and piety, but has no absolute value in itself. *[55]* Then all forms of religion become equally good, the Koran is put on a level with the word of God, and one cannot prove that Muhammad was a false prophet!—The draft of Spinoza's reply has been found, and one can see from it that he was for a moment brought out of his contemplative equilibrium and used strong expressions about the charge that was here directed against him. Even in the letter he sent Orobio de Castro in reply, he says that he does not know whether the writer of the letter spoke from malice or from ignorance. Can a man be accused of having put off all religion when he acknowledges God as the highest good, who ought to be loved by a free mind, when he finds in this love our highest happiness and our true freedom, and places the reward of virtue in virtue itself? Is there then nothing in virtue and knowledge themselves that can give joy, but must one look only to whether reward and punishment are in store, so that one

lets oneself be compelled like a slave and would rather follow one's desires, were it not for the threatening punishment? As for Muhammad, he was certainly a false prophet, for he denied the freedom that the true religion allows. But the spirit of Christ must nevertheless be said to be present among Turks and heathens alike, when their worship of God consists in justice and love of mankind.—In a later letter to Welthuysen himself, Spinoza acknowledges his striving after truth and his sincerity.

In Welthuysen's letter we see Spinoza called an atheist for the first time, though covertly (*clam*). That was the view of him that was the general one for over a hundred
[56] years. Bayle says of him that he is the first who brought atheism into a system. Voltaire has given expression to the same view in a satirical poem *(Les systèmes)*:

> Alors un petit juif, au long nez, au teint blème,
> Pauvre, mais satisfait, pensif et retiré,
> Esprit subtil et creux, moins lu que célébré,
> Caché sous le manteau de Descartes son maître,
> Marchant à pas comptés, s'approcha du Grand-Être:
> "Pardonnez-moi," dit il, en lui parlant tout bas,
> "Je crois, entre nous, que vous n'existez pas."

(See the end of the book.) It was—and to some extent still is—usual to call all those atheists who depart from the prevailing religious conceptions. To know what is meant by this word, one must therefore first know what is meant by God. As a rule one puts into the word atheism something more as well than the theoretical denial of the Deity; since God stands as the highest that can be thought, he who rejects his existence must necessarily—so it is inferred—be a low and contemptible man, one who denies what gives life its worth and higher significance. With respect to the extension of this concept there is therefore great disagreement. Abbé Mersenne, Descartes's friend, says that the number of atheists is so great that one must wonder that God lets them live; in Paris alone there are 50,000—one can find 12 together in a single house! But among the atheists he then also counts Charron, Machiavelli, Cardanus, Campanella, Vanini and Fludd.—Eilskov remarks in his "Filosofiske Breve" that most people call Spinoza's doctrine atheism, but he does not think they are right in this. "Spinoza did indeed confuse God with the world, in
[57] that he made both one substance; but he nevertheless granted to this one substance God's

foremost mark, that it existed by the necessity of its nature, consequently that everything that happened in the world was a consequence of the unalterable connection of things." Eilskov would therefore rather call Spinoza a deist than an atheist, rather say of him that he denied providence than that he denied God.—What separated Spinoza from the so-called deists was that the latter did not, to be sure, assume a providential government of particulars or a supernatural revelation, because everything since the creation went on according to the laws of nature established once and for all, but nevertheless assumed a personal God. What gave offense in Spinoza was precisely that he denied God as a single, determinate being, an object of representation and imagination. God did not stand for him outside nature,[8] but was what works and is in all nature. But for such a view a word was lacking, although it was not the first time it had been expressed. The word pantheism seems to have been introduced first by the English philosopher John Toland at the beginning of the eighteenth century. The new word was like a portent of the change in conception that was to take place. Toward the end of the century the greatest minds vied, after Lessing's example, in praising Spinoza; the pious Novalis called him *[58]* "a God-intoxicated man," and Schleiermacher in his "Speeches on Religion" pointed to Spinoza as a hero of religiousness. Only now did the positive side of Spinoza become the object of more general recognition; until then people had had eyes only for the negative. As long as the dualistic conception of nature continued to prevail, it could not be otherwise either. Spinoza was quite right when he said that his opponents conceived of nature in an entirely different way from him. For him the essential thing in nature was the eternal power and the eternal laws that reveal themselves in everything. But such a value his opponents, given their dualistic views, could not ascribe to nature; it stood for them as a power that drags man down, as finite and external, as a barrier beyond which they yearned.

It is illuminating with regard to Spinoza's concept of God, what he states in one of his letters, that he has just as clear a concept of God as of a triangle, but not as clear an image; we can think God, but not imagine him. Imagination gives us a single image, encloses the object in a given frame, but thought grasps—not the single object by itself—but the relation and connection between objects. That God is thought, not imagined, thus means

[8] Compare Heiberg's "Protestantismen i Naturen": The God you seek is your own God; what more would you have? He does not step forth as an object among many others. In seeking him, you have already found him; in asking, the answer is already won.

that he is conceived as the law or the power in everything, not as a single being subsisting by itself that has something outside itself. Precisely because the usual conception wants
[59] to grasp God in an image, it comes to set "the world" outside him. Yet there is hardly so great a difference between imagination and thought as Spinoza assumes. Although thought overcomes the oppositions and the glaring externality in which imagination easily entangles itself, it cannot itself avoid positing new oppositions; it establishes relations, lawfulness and connection, but thereby always presupposes a plurality of terms between which the relations hold and the laws apply. An absolute unity is the absolutely incomprehensible, precisely because it would not stand in relation to anything whatever. Our concepts do not reach beyond the world of phenomena and relations. That is not to say that our world is the only or the highest one; a consistent theory of knowledge leads to assuming an infinity of possibilities. What we can maintain is only that the truth and necessity we know must have their place and their validity within a possible larger connection. What this place is, we lack every means of deciding. But in working for what is true, beautiful and good, we are sure that we are working in the service of true reality. For such a monistic world-view Spinoza stands as the great prophet, although he went by speculative paths that we cannot tread with the same confidence as he. —

We have mentioned in an earlier place a letter from Spinoza's faithful friend Simon de Vries, in which the latter expresses his sorrow at being separated from him and calls a housemate of Spinoza's happy, because he always has access to him. In his reply Spinoza
[60] says that de Vries should not envy his housemate: "There is no one who is more of a burden to me, and with whom I am more on my guard. Therefore I ask you and all of you not to communicate my views to him until he has reached a more mature age. He is still too childish and inconstant, and is more eager for what is new than for what is true. But I hope that after the passage of some years he will correct these childish faults, and as far as I can judge from his character, I am sure of it, which is why I also love him for his good nature." It is no doubt the same young man of whom Spinoza tells in another letter that he would not initiate him into his own views and had therefore prepared an exposition of Descartes's philosophy for him. And finally we presumably meet the same person again in Spinoza's correspondence under the name of Albert de Burgh. He writes to Spinoza from Florence and begins by telling that he "by God's infinite mercy has become a member of the Catholic Church." He mentions his former admiration for Spinoza's

understanding and acuteness and for his ardent search for truth; but all the more does he now grieve that Spinoza is led about and enticed by "the wretched and insolent prince of the evil spirits." What is your whole philosophy but illusions and fantasies? And yet you build on it not only your spiritual peace in this life, but also the eternal salvation of your soul? You believe that you have found the best philosophy; but there have been and are so many philosophers who disagree with you! In your "Theologico-Political Treatise" you have tried with devilish cunning to separate theology from philosophy, *[61]* although in you yourself they coincide. You claim that what you say there about the teaching of Scripture you have learned from Scripture itself. But how dare you rely on your own interpretation? Only by the testimony of the whole Church and the apostolic traditions can Scripture be interpreted. You cannot appeal to the Protestants, for they are just as wretched as you and walk in just as great darkness. How dare you, a paltry man, a miserable worm that shall itself become food for worms, rely on your reason against the testimonies of the many holy and wise men the Church can show? Dare you consider yourself wiser than patriarchs, prophets, apostles, indeed Christ himself? Do you think you can explain everything? Is it not devilish pride that you would judge the terrible mysteries of Christ's life and death, which the Church declares incomprehensible? For so many years the Church has stood firm and unalterable, confirmed by miracles and by the heroism of the martyrs, and instead of bowing before it you would rather trust in the offspring of your own brain and make yourself more wretched than the beasts, however foolishly puffed up you are over the excellence of your mind and your teaching!—This letter I have written to you with a Christian intention, to show my love for you, although you are a heathen, and to beg you not to go on corrupting others.

Spinoza at first did not want to answer this letter, because he thought that reasons would make no impression here. But some common friends, who like himself had cherished good hopes for Burgh, persuaded him to make an attempt. He rebuts the young man's fanaticism in a dignified manner. —I do not imagine, he says, that I have found *[62]* the best philosophy, but I believe that I have insight into the true philosophy. There is no conviction so clear and certain as that which rests on clear reasons. The true makes itself evident to thought and thereby at the same time teaches us where falsehood lies *(verum est index sui et falsi).*[9] But you, who claim that you have found the best religion,

[9]In one of his letters to Bleyenbergh Spinoza says: When I have found a solid proof, I can never fall into

what reasons can you give for it, since you do not trust reason? If you appeal to the inner testimony of the Spirit, then all others can do the same. If you point to the excellent and holy men who have lived in the Roman Church, then all the sects among the Protestants can each bring a similar proof. All have had their martyrs. There were, as you know, some of your own family who under the Duke of Alba's regime suffered every possible torment for the sake of their faith. I myself have known a Jew by the name of Judas who, half dead, sang a psalm on the pyre of the Inquisition. If you point to the Roman Church's long past and continuous tradition, it is far surpassed by that of the Jews, who trace their lineage and their traditions right back to Adam, and whose religious community
[63] stands unshaken to this day, in spite of all persecutions past and present.—You, who once worshipped an infinite being, now worship a God whom Chastillon let his horses eat in the town of Tienen.[10] Acknowledge, then, that true Christianity consists in justice and love, and stop calling absurd errors mysteries!—

While the correspondents named so far[11] essentially represent the struggle of the old world-view against the new doctrine, which is incomprehensible to it, we still have two groups of Spinoza's correspondents left, both of which stand in a sympathetic relation to him; the one consists of his disciples proper, who adopted his doctrine, the other of those who see through it in such a way that they are able to direct a real philosophical critique against it and point beyond it to new paths for philosophical inquiry.

We have spoken above of Simon de Vries and his relation to Spinoza. In a similar
[64] beautiful relation of piety stood several young men, most of them physicians and of Jewish descent, belonging to the little circle that studied his doctrine from his manuscripts. A couple of beautiful letters have been found to one of these, Dr. med. Bresser. In the

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such thoughts that I doubt what I have proved, and therefore I rest content with what the understanding teaches me, without suspicion that I am deceived. And even if I come to see that I have been mistaken, I still regard it as good fortune, for I thereby take a step forward, and that can only increase the joy and tranquility with which I strive to lead my life.

[10] The Huguenot Marshal Chastillon threw consecrated hosts to the horses of his cavalrymen.

[11] Yet another name, and a very famous one, seems as if it must be mentioned here. Mr. A. D. Jørgensen, namely, has in the course of occupying himself with Steno's biography and writings come to the conviction that Steno, who studied in Leyden while Spinoza lived in nearby Rhynsburg, and who himself occupied himself with Cartesian philosophy, stood in close relation to Spinoza. His "*Epistola ad novæ philosophiæ reformatorem*," which was written after the famous anatomist and geologist's conversion to Catholicism, where he found peace for his brooding mind, seems to be directed against Spinoza (particularly against the "Theol.-Pol. Treatise"). He speaks of his opponent with great respect and alludes to their former intimate acquaintance. Unfortunately the work is not to be found in our libraries.

one, Spinoza complains that Bresser has left without taking leave of him. He urges him to correspond and encourages him to lay down a fixed plan of study and to devote the best part of his life to the cultivation of his mind. "So that you may take courage to write to me with greater freedom, you must know that I suspect that you have far too great a distrust of your abilities and therefore fear to come forward with questions or statements that might betray ignorance."—The other letter deals with the right method one should apply in one's studies. Spinoza stresses that—apart from the purely logical side of the matter—what counts is steady work of thought and firmness of mind and will, which cannot be attained unless one settles on a definite way of life and prescribes for oneself a definite goal.—In the advice he here gives his friend there lies an indication of the road he himself had traveled.

To the last group belong Leibnitz and Tschirnhausen. Of these Leibnitz has a famous name in the history of science; Tschirnhausen first really acquired interest for the history of philosophy when, through the previously mentioned discovery of Spinoza's manuscripts, it was found that he was the hitherto unknown author of the most acute of the letters addressed to Spinoza. However much these thinkers have in common with Spinoza, they nevertheless go beyond his standpoint. They at the same time represent the reaction against him, inasmuch as Leibnitz in particular again lets philosophy enter into *[65]*
a compromise with theology that was by no means to the advantage of the clarity and thoroughness of his thought. On the whole Leibnitz was the complete opposite of Spinoza. In place of the latter's concentrated calm and absorption in one thought there appears in the former an astonishing versatility: in mathematics and physics, in philosophy, history and jurisprudence he is at home, and everywhere he intervenes in an original way and makes new discoveries. While Spinoza keeps away from public life and spends his time grinding his lenses and pursuing his studies in his frugal room, Leibnitz throws himself into a whirl of practical affairs, frequents the courts, philosophizes with queens and princesses and theologizes with high ecclesiastical dignitaries. This many-sidedness and outward orientation were not to the advantage of his character as thinker and man. He readily came to terms and showed considerations he ought not to have shown. His conduct toward Spinoza shows him in a particularly unattractive light. In Spinoza's correspondence there is only one letter from Leibnitz to Spinoza and one from the latter to the former, and both deal with optical, not with philosophical, questions. But from the

manuscripts found in their time we obtain new information here as well. Tschirnhausen, who met Leibnitz in Paris, describes him as "free of the usual theological prejudices," and tells that he set great store by Spinoza's "Theologico-Political Treatise"; Leibnitz had even, according to his statement to Tschirnhausen, written an approving letter to Spinoza about this book; but it has unfortunately been lost. Later he has hinted that for a time
[66] he inclined toward Spinozism. Tschirnhausen asks Spinoza for permission to acquaint Leibnitz with the manuscript of the Ethics. But Spinoza will not yet give his consent to this. He can see from Leibnitz's letters, to be sure, that he is a man of free outlook and versed in all the sciences; but he will nevertheless wait to communicate his writings to him until he obtains closer information about his character and his activity in Paris.[12] The distrust that Spinoza thus intimates proved here—just as with Albert de Burgh—not to be unfounded. When Leibnitz, after his visit to Paris and London, returned to Germany by way of Holland, he visited Spinoza several times, as he himself relates, and talked with him at great length. But officially he would later not properly acknowledge this acquaintance. In his *Théodicée* he relates in passing that he visited Spinoza, but gives the impression that their conversation turned on "anecdotes of the time." To judge from the relation in which he then stood to Spinoza, and from the great problems with which both men were occupied, they surely talked about other things than anecdotes. Later Leibnitz in a letter described Spinoza as "*novateur trop connu*."—The acquaintance would have been compromising, especially for one who wished to have the appearance of being orthodox and wished to reconcile faith and knowledge. But what did Leibnitz gain by all his flirting with church doctrine? People did not believe him; the people of Hanover changed his name to "Løwenichts," i.e. Glaubenichts, and when he died no clergyman followed his coffin.

[67] It must not be forgotten, however, that Leibnitz really worked out a philosophical view whose strength lay precisely where Spinoza's weak side had been. Spinoza traced everything back to the one substance; but Leibnitz started from the idea that one and the same universe is apprehended in infinitely different ways at the different stages of development at which existing beings find themselves; there are thus really infinitely many worlds or substances, which he called monads. This way of looking at things is

[12] Leibnitz was at that time in the service of the Elector of Mainz and had traveled to Paris with great political plans.

not entirely foreign to Spinoza's system, but plays only a subordinate role there, and if definitely brought forward would lead to conflict with his fundamental view. The intermediary between Spinoza and Leibnitz, Tschirnhausen, has pointed precisely to this point in his letters to Spinoza.

Walther Ehrenfried von Tschirnhausen was a Saxon nobleman who in his youth traveled to Holland to study. He came into contact with the circle of Spinoza's young friends and through them with Spinoza himself. He is known as a mathematician and physicist (he is, among other things, the inventor of the burning glass) and as a philosopher stood close to Spinoza and Leibnitz. His work *Medicina mentis*, a kind of logic, has so much in common with Spinoza's treatise "On the Emendation of the Intellect" that he has even been accused of plagiarism. In any case his most important doctrines are a further development of what Spinoza had already taught, and he often uses even the same words and turns of phrase. In a few places he alludes to Spinoza, but never names him (only as *qvidam* or in a similar way), naturally for the same reason as the one that led Leibnitz to *[68]* such great caution. Tschirnhausen had, moreover, dedicated his work to Louis XIV in order to obtain a pension.—Here he interests us as the author of those letters in Spinoza's correspondence that betray the sharpest eye for the system's fundamental concepts and thereby also for its weak sides. It is significant that these letters were written at the time when Tschirnhausen was associating with Leibnitz in Paris; the points they touch on are precisely the ones that came into their own in Leibnitz's philosophy.

The exchange between Tschirnhausen and Spinoza concerns two main points. How can one derive from the general concept of extension the manifold actually existing bodies with their determinate figure and motion? With this question the whole deductive and abstractly mathematical method that Descartes had introduced into philosophy, and that Spinoza had brought to its completion, is struck. In extension in itself there lies neither figure nor motion. Descartes, as Tschirnhausen remarks, was even better placed on this point; he saw that motion could not be derived from mere extension, and assumed that God at the creation had imparted to matter the motion it had. But Spinoza, who has of course given up this theological notion, cannot explain actual motion.[13] Spinoza replies to this that Descartes's concept of matter as mass at rest was unsatisfactory, but that he

[13]This objection to Spinoza's doctrine was later set out at greater length in an acute essay by John Toland in his Letters to Serena (1704).

[69] himself had not yet properly thought the matter through. He expresses himself in this debate with a lack of assurance that must be explained by the fact that here he stood at the historical limit of his thought. A new concept was necessary in the conception of nature, a concept that Leibnitz in particular brought forward both in physics and in philosophy: the concept of force. Spinoza has, to be sure, as we shall see, put this concept in the closest connection with his fundamental concept, substance, but it does not yet pervade his conception of nature, and on closer consideration it proves to stand in disharmony with the concept of substance as Spinoza conceives it.—But what offended Tschirnhausen in Spinoza's conception of matter was not merely its one-sided determination as extension in space, whereby the properly physical was set aside; it was also the demand that material phenomena should be derived from one single concept. In order to draw conclusions, he says, we always need several concepts; from a single one we cannot derive a plurality of determinations. When, for example, I consider the circumference of the circle alone, I can conclude nothing from it except that it is everywhere equal to itself and uniform, whereby it differs from other curves; but other properties I cannot derive. When, on the other hand, I also take other things into account, namely the radii drawn from the center, two or more lines intersecting one another, etc., then I can derive further properties from this. Spinoza replies that this holds in mathematics and logic, but not as regards real concepts, and therefore not for the concept of substance either; but he does not indicate
[70] where this difference should come from. Tschirnhausen's objection is of great interest because it points to the law of relativity, which is more and more recognized in philosophy. Every sensation, every representation and every thought stands in connection with other sensations, representations and thoughts, and is possible only in and through such a connection. Before something absolute and self-contained in and for itself, thought therefore stands powerless; it cannot think it, because there is nothing with which it can compare and measure it. Tschirnhausen's objection, which is directed only at the concept of matter, strikes the very fundamental concept in Spinoza; for his "substance" is that which exists in itself and is to be understood through itself; but everything we understand, we always understand by means of something else. The necessity of striking out on another path and using another method than Spinoza's becomes evident here.

Tschirnhausen's second question concerns Spinoza's doctrine that substance reveals itself under infinitely many attributes or fundamental forms, but that we know only two

of them (mind and matter). Spinoza's line of thought was this: the more perfect a being is, the more fundamental forms it must also have under which to reveal itself, and since God is the infinite being, his essence must express itself in an infinity of fundamental forms. But, says Tschirnhausen, since every thing belongs to the essence of God or substance, every thing must be expressed under infinitely many fundamental forms, and there are thus really infinitely many worlds. And even if it is one substance that exists under the infinitely many attributes, one universe that is apprehended in infinitely many ways, *[71]* still we know only two of these ways, and the other fundamental forms thus become like foreign worlds to us.—Here we are brought close to the change that Leibnitz, as just indicated, introduced into the concept of substance. Leibnitz's monads correspond to the infinitely many attributes of the Spinozistic substance, for the world is represented in each monad in a peculiar way. By putting the monad in place of substance Leibnitz paved the way for the critical philosophy, which starts from the idea that what we know about the world is conditioned by the nature and conditions of our consciousness and therefore holds only from our standpoint. Spinoza boldly started from the idea of the absolute being and maintained an absolute truth; he still saw only imperfectly that "what is seen depends on the eyes that see," and that we know light only as refracted into a multiplicity of rays. It is a truth that English philosophy, Leibnitz, Kant, the physiology of the senses and the hypothesis of evolution have each in its own way expressed.

Thus we see Spinoza in his correspondence placed between past and future. We see his thought in its justified struggle against prejudices, as well as in its limitation, where it meets the seeds of the future.

Spinoza's Philosophy

I.

Spinoza begins his main work, the Ethics, with a series of definitions that already give us *[72]* his whole system in brief. "By cause of itself"—so runs the first definition—"I understand that whose essence involves existence, or, in other words, that which cannot be conceived except as existing." To this the third definition attaches itself: "By substance I understand that which is in itself and is conceived through itself, that is, that whose concept does not need the concept of any other thing from which it must be formed." That which exists in and through itself must also be the cause of itself. For what springs from something else, or has its cause outside itself, cannot be understood in and through itself alone, and so cannot be substance. As cause of itself, substance is eternal. For by eternity I understand, says Spinoza, the very existence of things, insofar as it follows from the concept of things. Substance is, further, infinite. For finitude is limitation and negation, and if substance *[73]* were finite, its existence would depend on something other than its own essence.

The essence and content of substance find their expression in the attributes. By attribute Spinoza understands what thought conceives of substance as making up (constituting) its essence. The attributes are definitions of substance, are each by itself substance itself from one particular side. The attribute must therefore, like substance, be conceived in and through itself: each attribute by itself is infinite and eternal, and the one attribute cannot be explained by means of the other, the one has not arisen from the other.

While substance is that which exists in itself and is explained through itself, Spinoza understands by mode *(modus)* that which has its existence in something else and is understood only through this. All modes are therefore more particular determinations *(affectiones)* of substance. Everything that is thus falls into two classes: either it has its

existence in itself (substance) or in another (modi),— either it has an unconditioned or a conditioned existence.

These are the three fundamental concepts in Spinoza. If we look for Danish names for them, we might perhaps call substance *Grundvæsen* (fundamental being), attribute *Grundform* (fundamental form), mode *Enkeltvæsen* (individual being). The individual beings thus have their existence in the fundamental being, and this manifests itself in the fundamental forms. The higher a being stands, the more fundamental forms it has. The one and infinite fundamental being, which exists under infinitely many fundamental forms, we call God. God exists with necessity; his existence is grounded in his essence.
[74] Or suppose that God does not exist: there would then have to be something that hindered and excluded his existence; but where should this something be, since God is the infinite fundamental being outside of which there is nothing? Besides God no fundamental being can be given or conceived. Everything that exists thus has existence only as a particular form of the one fundamental being.

As that which is conceived in and through itself, the fundamental being is the starting point of thought; only through it is everything else understood. The right way to philosophize is, says Spinoza, to start from the highest cause. But since all existence is included in the fundamental being, Spinoza's philosophy not only has its starting point in this concept; it cannot, if it wants to be consistent, get beyond it. If Spinoza assumes an existence that lies outside the fundamental being, he contradicts himself: there would then be something outside the one that is.

Of the infinitely many fundamental forms of the infinite being we know only two: thought and extension. By extension Spinoza understands, as we know, what we call matter, since he regards the geometrical properties as the essential ones. Extension is a form of God's essence. One is right, to be sure, that God is not corporeal; for a body is a determinate and limited figure. But extended or corporeal nature is not outside God or created by God. The fundamental form (the attribute) is, after all, the fundamental being (substance) itself, eternal and infinite as this is. People regard it as unworthy to make the corporeal an expression of God's essence; but that is only because they always think
[75] of finite bodies, which can be divided and dissolved. The fundamental being as such is indivisible and eternal. Thus water as water can be divided, and its parts separated from one another, but not insofar as it is substance.—Spinoza stands here as a forerunner

of the doctrine of the conservation of matter, which modern chemistry has confirmed experimentally. The various particular substances can be dissolved and converted into one another, but no matter perishes, no atom is added and none is lost.—While Spinoza conducts a special defense of his ascribing to God the fundamental form of extension, he does not do so as regards the fundamental form of thought, since here he can rely on the common conception of God as spirit.

According to Spinoza, then, we know God as the infinite power that works in the world of thought as well as in that of matter. But we are naturally led here to ask why we know only these two fundamental forms among the infinitely many. The reason does not lie far off: we know ourselves as conscious and material beings, and fundamental forms other than consciousness and matter are not accessible to us in the world of experience. This leads us to see how Spinoza arrived at the concept of attribute or fundamental form at all. He lays down this concept simply by a definition, without mentioning its origin. But it is really won by an analysis of what is given in experience. Everything we know can be referred to two great groups: phenomena of consciousness and material phenomena. This is the deepest-lying difference we find in the whole world of experience. That Spinoza's "attribute" is really only the characteristic mark of one of these groups can be seen from *[76]* the fact that he (right at the beginning of the "Ethics") uses the expression "kind" in the same sense as "attribute." In the same sense he further also uses the expression "nature," and in an earlier work "property or quality" *(proprietas sive qvalitas sive attributum. Princ. phil. Cartes. I. def. 5).* The attribute is thus really a quality, a peculiarity, that gives a certain group or class of phenomena its fundamental stamp. Spinoza sets up as the 5th axiom in the second book of the "Ethics": "We feel and perceive no particular things other than bodies and modes of thought"; and relying on this he then proves that extension and thought are divine attributes. Here the real origin of the concept lies plainly in view.

Spinoza conceives the attribute as the expression of the essence of substance. Where, then, does he get the idea of substance? With him it is immediately given, as what is in itself clearest and most evident in our knowledge. He therefore determines it straight away by a definition. Its being (God's existence) is an eternal truth. But if we look more closely, we shall be able to trace the real origin here too. In his exposition of Descartes's philosophy Spinoza says (I. def. 5): "Every thing in which, or through which, something that we perceive, i.e., a property, a quality or an attribute, has its existence, is called

substance." "Being as such, as substance in and for itself, does not affect us, and therefore it must be explained by an attribute, from which it can nevertheless be distinguished only logically" *(Cogit. metaph. I, 3, 1).* Here we see the traces of the method by which
[77] knowledge in reality climbs upward to reach what is substantial in things: experience and the analysis of experiences.[14]

But experience can, says Spinoza, teach us only the existence of finite things, not the fundamental being and the fundamental forms. The particular things we can learn from experience we understand rightly only when we already know the inner essence of things.[15] He therefore skips the path of experience and analysis as useless and begins by defining the idea of the fundamental being, which he regards as immediately clear and evident. It would be a self-contradiction for him that what includes all being in itself should be known through something else. Experience is for him a ladder that reaches only
[78] halfway, and which it occurs to him all the less to use, as he feels himself on the heights from the very beginning. When a mathematician defines, his definition is one with a construction, since it states how the thing defined comes into being. In the definition of the circle as a line in which every point is at the same distance from a certain given point lies the instruction for constructing a circle by letting a straight line move about one of its end points. But for such a construction we have nothing corresponding as regards the abstract metaphysical concepts. For Spinoza it stood as a contradiction that what is in itself should not exist. "To be able to exist is a power, and the more reality belongs to the nature of a thing, the more powers it has in itself to exist: hence the absolutely infinite being, or God, has absolute power in itself to exist, and therefore exists absolutely. Many will perhaps not easily see the evidence of this proof, because they are accustomed to consider only the things that spring from external causes. But I am speaking here only of

[14] In *Descartes* it is stated still more definitely that the concept of substance is reached in this way. "Substance cannot originally be known merely from its being an existing thing, for that by itself alone does not affect us; but we easily come to know it from one of its attributes. For from seeing that some attribute or other is present, we *conclude* that there must necessarily also be present an existing thing or a substance to which this attribute can be ascribed" (*Princ. phil. 1. 52*).—In his polemic against Descartes, *Gassendi* rightly lays great weight on the fact that we reach the concept of substance by inference. That is why, he says, this concept is so abstract, indistinct and problematic, and it is not the knowledge of the properties (the accidents) that depends on the knowledge of substance, but conversely the knowledge of substance that depends on the knowledge of the properties. (*Disqvisitio metaphysica. Amstelod. 1644 p. 121—123*).

[15] In a note to the unfinished treatise "On the Emendation of the Intellect" Spinoza says that he intends to examine in detail the empirical method that the modern philosophers employ. Unfortunately he did not carry out this plan.

the fundamental being, which cannot be produced by any external cause. For the things that arise through external causes receive all the perfection or reality they have from the power of the external cause, and their existence springs solely from the perfection of the external cause, not from their own. On the other hand, the perfection that the fundamental being possesses is owed to no external cause, and therefore its existence must follow from its nature alone. There is therefore nothing of whose existence we can be more certain than of the existence of the absolutely infinite and perfect being." We now understand why Spinoza begins his system with the definition of the concept "cause of itself." We understand, further, that this concept could not be grounded in experience, *[79]* which always shows us one thing conditioned and effected by another. It is thus an idea of reason that Spinoza presupposes, and just as anyone who has the ability to form and intuit figures in space can be compelled to acknowledge the reality of the circle, so Spinoza holds that anyone who thinks through the concept "cause of itself" must assume the existence of such a cause.

Beyond and behind this concept we cannot get in Spinoza. Only by taking an entirely different starting point and applying another method can one come to put the concept of what is in itself up for debate. That happens in the empirical philosophy in England and in the critical philosophy in Germany. What for Spinoza stood as the most certain of all, the first and deepest starting point of thought, now becomes precisely the most problematic, the most difficult concept of all. Kant's concept of the "thing in itself" (das Ding an sich) is directly reminiscent of Spinoza's definition of substance; but Kant designates by it precisely what constantly eludes our knowledge, the limiting concept in the world of thought.

In his "Short Treatise on God and Man" Spinoza mentions (I. 7) the objection that God cannot be defined, because every definition takes place by referring the thing defined to a certain kind or class, whereas God, of course, cannot be referred to any class. He grants that this is the doctrine of ordinary logic about definition, but does not hesitate to reject it as regards the fundamental being. Substance, says he, is after all a being existing *[80]* through itself, which is known in and through itself. It is only of the things that do not exist through themselves that it holds that they are defined by being referred to a certain class. Here, then, Spinoza maintains that the knowledge we have of substance is of an entirely different kind from the rest of our knowledge. The question then is whether

there really is such a double mode of knowledge, or whether the kind and manner of our knowledge is not essentially the same throughout. We shall return to this question in treating Spinoza's theory of knowledge.

As we have seen above, Tschirnhausen had already stopped at the difficulty that the one fundamental being should reveal itself under infinitely many fundamental forms, of which we nevertheless know only two. Two tendencies in Spinoza clash here, as Kuno Fischer has clearly shown. According to his fundamental thought, that all is one, what holds for substance must also hold for the individual beings; but more powerful than this striving to conceive the absolute as immanent is his presupposition of its infinite exaltation above every finite being. This exaltation shows itself in the fact that, while we as finite beings have only two attributes, the infinite being has infinitely many. Here we thus have a point where it can be seen with how much right I maintained in the Introduction that Spinoza's speculative principle, the idea of the absolute substance, is rightly understood only when one goes beyond philosophy, back to the religious
[81] consciousness. In a note to the "Short Treatise" just mentioned (I, 1)[16] it is said: "After we have considered nature, we have so far been unable to find in it more than two fundamental forms that belong to the all-perfect being itself. These are not now enough for us; they cannot be the only thing of which this most perfect being consists. On the contrary, we find in ourselves something that plainly announces to us not merely more, but infinitely many perfect fundamental forms, which must belong to that being for it to be called perfect. But this something cannot spring from the two fundamental forms; for two give only two and not infinitely many. From where, then? Not from myself; for I cannot give what I do not have. From where else, then, but from the infinite fundamental forms themselves, which tell us that they are, without at the same time telling us *what* they are; for only of two do we know what they are." This is the only hint that occurs in Spinoza's writings in this respect, and it has an almost mystical character. This side of the matter, too, we shall return to under Spinoza's theory of knowledge. That a great truth nevertheless lies hidden in Spinoza's idea of the infinitely many fundamental forms of the fundamental being, we have already seen above. Precisely when we see the relativity of our knowledge, its dependence on our nature and on our position in existence, and

[16] It must be remarked, however, that it is not quite certain whether the notes to this work derive from Spinoza himself.

thus renounce an absolute knowledge, we cannot but grant the possibility of infinitely many other standpoints on the same existence.

Although Spinoza, by calling the fundamental being God, indicates this concept's *[82]* kinship with the object of religious faith, he nevertheless gives more particular determinations that remove the popular notions of God. Nothing, he teaches, can be or be conceived without God. But from the necessity of the divine nature there follows an infinity of effects. God acts according to the necessity of his nature; there is nothing outside him that could determine or hinder his acting. This is true freedom, which is one with inner necessity. God is the only free cause: finite beings all have something outside themselves that hinders them from following their nature. And since it is grounded in God's nature that infinite effects spring from it, these effects must be eternal. God has from eternity produced everything that he produces. If anything remained that he had not yet managed to produce, his omnipotence would not be eternal. In God there is no difference between possibility and actuality. His essence and acting are an eternal actuality. Time, number and measure find no application to the fundamental being. In the eternal there is no past or future. When one ascribes intellect and will to God, these words must be taken in an entirely different sense from when they are used of men; the likeness becomes merely a likeness of name, like that between the dog, the barking animal, and the constellation of the same name. It would be especially wrong to think of God as acting according to purposes; that would be to subordinate him to a higher power, to place something outside him by which he directed himself in his acting; that is, it would be to abolish the very concept of God. The word personality, which the theologians use to designate God's essence, is far too indefinite and unclear to be used *[83]* with profit.

The question presents itself here how the divine acting is to be understood when all difference of time and all difference between possibility and actuality is to be excluded. Light on this lies, in the first place, in the very concept "cause of itself." The acting of the fundamental being produces nothing but itself: its producing of everything coincides with its producing of itself. "The essence and existence of things," says Spinoza, "are a necessary consequence of the divine nature. God must be called the cause of all things in the same sense in which he is called the cause of himself. Finite beings are nothing but determinations *(affectiones)* of God's attributes, or forms *(modi)*, in which God's attributes

are expressed in a certain determinate way." Just as by understanding we understand both the source of thoughts and the sum of all thoughts, so God is the source of all things and the sum of all things, the cause of everything and the totality of everything. God is, in other words, an indwelling (immanent, reflexive) cause, not a transcending (transcendent) cause; what he produces is not something outside him, but a form of his own essence.— But in the second place it must be stressed that Spinoza often uses, as a paraphrase for "the acting of the Deity," the expression "consequence of the nature of the Deity," and even suggests that this latter designation is the most correct. The comparison Spinoza so often uses points in the same direction: that everything follows from God's essence with the same necessity with which it follows from the essence of the triangle
[84] that the sum of its angles is equal to two right angles. The relation between ground and consequence thus takes the place of that between cause and effect. In the relation between ground and consequence time plays no role; the consequence does not come to be, but is eternally one with the ground. Spinoza's conception thus becomes this: that everything is as in an eternal now, because it has its ground in the infinite substance, where no differences of time hold.

Just as the concept of the fundamental being, on consistent consideration, coincided with the concept of God, so the concept of God in turn coincides with the concept of nature. "That infinite being, which we call God or nature, acts with the same necessity with which it exists." But Spinoza now distinguishes between two forms of the essence of the Deity or of nature: *producing* nature *(natura naturans)*, God as free cause, and *produced* nature *(natura naturata)*, the totality of individual beings, which can neither be nor be conceived without God. And within produced nature a further distinction is made between what springs *immediately* from God's essence and what springs from it only *mediately*. What follows immediately from God's eternal and infinite nature must itself be eternal and infinite. By this one is to think of the order of nature as a whole, the laws holding in the whole universe, within the world of mind as well as within the world of matter. But what is finite and has a limited existence cannot be produced immediately by God's absolute nature. The finite can therefore be produced by God only insofar as he appears in limited and finite form: the one finite thing is thus determined by another, this
[85] by a third, and so on to infinity. Each individual being is a link in the chain of nature and is determined by the other links in this chain.—Here an entirely different causal relation

is introduced from the one that holds for the fundamental being. The individual beings stand independent, outside of and over against one another, and act as mechanical causes, whereas the fundamental being acts only as an indwelling and reflexive cause, never upon anything but itself, never meeting resistance.

Spinoza says in one of his letters that the concept of necessity is the chief foundation of his doctrine. He denies that there is anything contingent. "If men clearly understood the whole order of nature, they would find everything just as necessary as all the propositions of mathematics." But necessity thus appears in his system in a double form: as inner necessity in the nature and acting of the fundamental being, and as outer necessity in the interaction and mutual determinations of the individual beings. Now since the fundamental being is Spinoza's first and last thought, he ought consistently to have stopped at inner necessity; but then the world of individual beings, concrete actuality, would have received no reality. Every particular and finite thing is, according to Spinoza, a limitation and a determination of the essence of substance; and, he adds, every determination is a negation. For the determination does not necessarily belong to the nature of the thing: where the limit is set, the thing, after all, ceases to be. Every determinate figure is thus a negation, an abolition of infinite extension. To posit a particular finite thing as existing is to abolish God's existence. Spinoza does teach expressly, to be sure, that although every particular thing is determined by another thing to exist in a certain way, the power *[86]* by which it persists in its existence nevertheless follows from the eternal necessity of God's nature. But this power must nevertheless always itself be a determination and thus, on Spinoza's conception, a negation; it must be related to the infinite divine power as figure is related to the whole of matter, and from the essence of substance one cannot derive what abolishes substance. In Spinoza's system there can really be no room for an outer necessity, an interaction between real individual beings. If these are each of them negations, they cannot affect and determine one another; for from nothing comes nothing. When Spinoza nevertheless teaches such an outer necessity and presents nature as a world of elements that shape themselves into greater and smaller wholes according to the laws of their interaction, this doctrine is not won by the deductive path. It rests on a presupposition that is not contained in the idea of the fundamental being, and he himself has stated in one of his letters that it is experience he builds on here. To the duality within his system there thus corresponds a duality in his method: the fundamental being and

the individual beings are related to each other as speculation and experience. Spinoza lays speculation at the foundation and uses experience only where speculation does not suffice. Here he stands in clear opposition to present-day philosophizing, which as a rule lays experience at the foundation and lets speculation build its hypotheses on the basis of empirical knowledge. This is all the more natural a procedure since only in this way
[87] does it become possible to check the very principles from which speculation starts. But it shows Spinoza's profundity that even a method so altered leads thought to a world-view akin to his. Thus workmen who dig a tunnel through a mountain, each from his own side, will meet in the middle, provided only that they go the right way, each from his own starting point.

Jakobi regarded Spinoza as the only consistent philosopher and gave the choice between his doctrine and a *salto mortale* into faith. Later criticism discovered, to the joy of many, the double current and to that extent the inconsistency in Spinoza. The iron ring seemed broken. But it must be well noted that the double current does not first appear at a certain point inside the system, but is present in the first design, in the definitions and axioms with which it begins. When Spinoza begins not only with the definition of "cause of itself" and of "fundamental being," but in the same breath defines the "individual being," and when his first axiom is: everything that is, is *either* in itself *or* in another,—then he in reality begins not with one but with two presuppositions, draws from the very first on two different sources. And the duality is in reality only on the surface; the two currents obey one and the same fundamental law: it is the idea of lawful connection that governs everything in Spinoza, and that attests a deeper unity behind the duality that criticism can point out.

The proposition that every determination is a negation *(omnis determinatio est negatio)*
[88] has often, and rightly, been cited as characteristic of Spinoza's standpoint. For him the positive was what exists in itself, which is raised above all relations and all limits. But this conception is struck by Goethe's well-known words: "In der Begrenzung zeigt sich erst der Meister." It is precisely our task to win determinations, to grasp nuances, to determine relations. We find the positivity of thought in the rich, manifold and articulated content it is able to win. Only through determination does the content become positive. Every determination, we might say, is a relation; each time we think something, we determine its relations and only thereby come to know it *(omnis determinatio est relatio)*.

Our knowledge is relative, and only thereby is it also positive. One will also easily see that the absolute and infinite, what exists in itself, can be thought and designated only in a negative way, by negation of the finite determinations. What exists in *itself* we cannot explain otherwise than as that which does *not* need *anything else* in order to exist. What Spinoza regarded as the true, the only positive, is thus precisely negative, is a limiting concept that is thought only by means of the determinations that are negated in it.

II.

The distinctive and consistent carrying through of the concept of substance is the first *[89]* and most epoch-making feature of Spinoza's philosophy. But closely connected with this is another main point. If one fundamental being reveals itself in everything, the relation between mind and matter cannot be such as it is commonly imagined to be. Spinoza holds, like Descartes, that the difference between the inner world of thoughts and extension in space is for us insurmountable; thought and extension are for him two fundamental forms in which the fundamental being reveals itself, wholly and fully in each of them. From the definition of the fundamental form it then follows directly how the relation between mind and matter must be. By fundamental form or attribute Spinoza understands, after all, what thought asserts of substance as making up its essence. But as an expression of substance or the fundamental being, every fundamental form must be conceived in and through itself; the fundamental form is, after all, only the fundamental being itself, seen from a certain side. The one fundamental form therefore cannot have been produced by the other: mind not by matter, matter not by mind; all fundamental forms are original and simultaneous. One and the same fundamental being reveals itself at once under different forms, of which the one does not exclude the other. Each particular mode of expression *[90]* of a fundamental form must therefore be understood and explained through other modes of expression of the same fundamental form, and not through determinations that belong under another fundamental form: thoughts can be explained only by thoughts, material motions only by material motions. The cause must everywhere be of the same kind as the effect. But since it is one and the same fundamental being that reveals itself in the two fundamental forms, there will be a parallelism present: the order and connection of thoughts is the same as the order and connection of things. God's power of thought

and his power of action correspond to each other, and everything that follows from God's infinite nature within the world of thought follows in the same order and the same connection within the world of matter. Whether, therefore, we conceive nature as matter or as mind, it is one and the same causal series we have before us. And if other fundamental forms were accessible to us, the case would be the same with them; each by itself would be an expression of the one fundamental being, coherent in itself and revealed in an infinite series of phenomena.

It is characteristic of Spinoza's standpoint and procedure that he begins by determining the relation between mind and matter in its generality, and only then passes on to the relation between soul and body. This relation is a particular example of that general relation.—Conceived under the fundamental form of mind, the fundamental being manifests itself in a world of thoughts. The human mind is one of these infinitely many thoughts. When we say, then, that the human mind perceives this or that, it means that
[91] the fundamental being, not insofar as it is infinite, but insofar as it finds its expression in the nature of the human mind, or makes up (constitutes) the essence of the human mind, has this or that thought. To each particular thought there corresponds, within the fundamental form of extension, a material motion. The various consciousnesses and the various thoughts differ from one another in the same degree as the corresponding material motions and bodies differ from one another. The more impressions the body is capable of receiving, the more ideas the consciousness is also fitted to perceive; and the more independent and active the body is, the more clearly and distinctly the mind is able to think. Since the fundamental forms are each by itself infinite, this must hold for everything actual: everything in nature is thus animate, although in different degrees. Every existing being has—as a member of the fundamental being—a double side from which it can be seen, is both mental and material.—Since it here becomes of interest to know the different nature of bodies, Spinoza inserts some propositions from natural philosophy.

Bodies differ from one another only by the different ratio between motion and rest. Every body is determined to motion or rest by another body, this by a third, and so on. The way in which a body is determined depends partly on its own nature, partly on the nature of the body that affects it. One and the same body is moved differently according to the difference of the bodies affecting it, and different bodies are moved in different

ways by one and the same body.

From the simplest, most elementary bodies there are formed composite bodies. For *[92]* when bodies of the same or different size are held together by other bodies in such a way that they fit together with one another, or when they communicate their motions to one another in a certain determinate ratio, they are said to be united with one another and all together form one body or one individual, which is distinguished from other individuals by the determinate union among the particular bodies of which it consists. Such an individual remains the same even if some parts are separated off and others taken in, and even if the size of the parts and the direction of the motions are altered, provided only that the whole form of the composition remains the same.

Several such particular individuals can now be thought of as united into an individual of the second order; several of this latter kind again into an individual of the third order, and so on. Finally we then conceive the whole of nature as a single great individual, whose particular parts vary infinitely without the whole individual undergoing any change.

The way in which Spinoza here develops the concept of the individual is entirely in the spirit of modern natural science. Instead of seeking inner, mystical unities, he seeks the law that holds for the coming into being of the individual. Only thus can the concept of individuality be maintained in the face of the difficulty that experience shows us no absolute and sharply marked boundaries between particular beings. It is a necessary consequence of modern natural inquiry that one must either give up the concept of individuality altogether or else make it relative, use it in a wider range, so that we, like *[93]* Spinoza, get individuals of different degrees.

In teaching an ascending series of degrees of individuality in nature, Spinoza has at the same time expressed the law of development in one of its most characteristic forms: the transition from lesser to greater coherence. His account is a forerunner of Herbert Spencer's *First Principles.*[17]

If we now recall that to every material form, every bodily individual, there corresponds an ideal form, an individual thought, since everything is animate, although in different degrees,[18]—then Spinoza appears as a precursor of Leibnitz's doctrine of monads. Just

[17] See my work "Den engelske Filosofi i vor Tid." Kbhvn. 1874. P. 136 ff.

[18] One would entirely misunderstand Spinoza's doctrine of the universal animation of nature if one supposed (as, e.g., *John Toland* does in the essay mentioned earlier) that it is meant as an attempt to explain

as the human body consists of many composite individuals of different nature, so the thought that makes up the nature of the human mind is also composed of many thoughts.
[94] The whole of nature consists of an infinity of individual beings, each with its degree of representative power. And it is precisely such beings that Leibnitz calls monads.[19]

On this point too Spinoza's view is decidedly monism. Just as little as he could grant a dualistic relation between the fundamental being and the individual beings, could he grant one between mental and material phenomena. Everywhere he seeks the unity that lies behind the differences. And this striving of his stands out especially strongly when one compares him with his predecessor in philosophy, Descartes. In the Cartesian philosophy soul and body were two entirely different substances, which could really be connected with each other only by a miracle. Although Descartes, who had cultivated anatomy with zeal, had a conception of the significance of the nervous system so clear and apt for his time that modern neurophysiology has its predecessor in him,[20] it was nevertheless in a purely external way that he thought of the soul as connected with the body. In the so-called "pineal gland" in the brain he saw the place[21] where the soul acts on the bodily and in turn is affected by it. Spinoza remarks in his critique of this
[95] doctrine that the mental and the material have no common measure, cannot be compared with each other and therefore cannot determine each other either. Neither can the body determine the soul to think, nor the soul the body to motion or rest or anything else whatever. What determines the soul to thinking must itself be a thought, and what sets the body in motion or rest must itself be a body. Soul and body are one and the same thing, which is considered now under the fundamental form of thought, now under that of extension. We do not have—as in Descartes—first a bodily motion that sets the soul in motion, and then a mental activity; but since the bodily motion in itself (in the

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how motion arises in matter. Spinoza denies, after all, in the most definite way that thought and matter can act on each other. His line of thought is rather this: that matter is homogeneous in all its forms and compositions; when, therefore, at a certain point we find phenomena of consciousness connected with material motions, then all material motions, although in very different degrees, must be accompanied by such. (*Et. II, 13. Schol.*) This theory arose in Spinoza through the resolute way in which he carries through the unity and coherence of the material world. It still stands as a natural hypothesis, and has in our time been put forward not only by philosophers but also by natural scientists such as Zøllner, Haeckel and others.

[19] From another side—as pointed out earlier—Spinoza points forward to Leibnitz by the doctrine of the infinitely many fundamental forms of the one fundamental being.

[20] He was, according to *Huxley*, to the nervous system what Harvey was to the circulation of the blood.

[21] That the "pineal gland" has no such significance *Steno* had already shown in a treatise of 1669.

fundamental being) is one with the mental act, the difference in time falls away.

Spinoza feels that the deductive proof (from the concept of the fundamental form) will not be enough here. "People are," he says, "firmly convinced that the body moves or rests at the mere nod of the soul, and that it performs much that depends on the soul's will and ingenuity. Therefore people will hardly consider the matter calmly unless I draw proofs from experience." He then remarks first that no one can know how far the power of the body reaches. No one has yet found the limit of what can be brought about according to the laws of material nature. It is thus quite arbitrary to set definite bounds here, beyond which nothing is supposed to be possible except through the soul's intervention.—But what does one really mean when one speaks of the soul setting the body in motion? No one can form a clear and distinct concept of it. To say that the soul brings about a bodily motion is thus the same as to say that one does not know how this motion comes *[96]* about. Here, as so often, people dress up their ignorance in fine-sounding words.—In the instinctive actions of animals, in the behavior of sleepwalkers and somnambulists, we have cases where bodily nature acts alone, and where it accomplishes things that everyone admires.—Further, experience shows that the liveliness and activity of the soul stand in a definite relation to the bodily condition. Things would certainly stand far better if men had the ability to govern their bodies. But they do not even have their tongues in their power. And yet the chatterer believes he acts entirely freely, however often he comes to regret his openness of mouth. Since man does not know the causes that determine his acting, he regards himself as absolutely free, just as the stone, if it could think, would suppose that it fell to the earth of its own free will.—We cannot, after all, act according to our decision unless we remember what it amounts to. But we are not always masters of memory. Everyone must grant that we cannot at every moment call up before our thought whatever we like. Thoughts and decisions arise in consciousness with the same necessity as the representations of external objects. And the necessary law that holds for consciousness corresponds to the one that holds for the corresponding bodily process: "The decision or desire of the mind and the determination of the body are by their nature simultaneous, or rather, they are one and the same thing, which we call decision when it is considered under the attribute of thought and explained through it, and bodily determination when it is considered under the attribute of extension and *[97]* derived from the laws of motion and rest."

This whole doctrine belongs to what secures Spinoza's writings a lasting significance. He has here in a brilliant way anticipated an insight whose empirical working out our own time has only now reached. He had some ground to build on, namely Descartes's mechanical neurophysiology. But here, as on several points, Descartes stopped halfway. Spinoza's eye for unity and connection led him to the conviction that the series of bodily causes cannot be thought of as broken at any point. If it now nevertheless remains firm that there is a (for us) insurmountable difference between consciousness and matter (or in Spinoza's language: thought and extension), then the only possible conception becomes that of thinking of these two forms of existence as simultaneous and parallel expressions of one and the same fundamental being. The physiology and psychology of our own time also seem to lead to a similar conception.[22]

For Spinoza as a speculative philosopher the matter stood thus: that the fundamental being, which lies behind mind and matter, is what is clearest and most certain for thought. For us it makes the head swim at this height. We rejoice to see the threads draw closer to one another the further we are able to follow them, to see even the oppositions that are insurmountable for us within the circle of our experiences point back to a deeper
[98] unity; but this unity itself we are not able to bring forth; each time thought tries to hold it fast, it turns out that we are on the point of leaving the proper domain of our knowledge. From the trackless regions of speculative hypotheses we then seek our way back to what Kant has called "the fruitful depth of experience." We are therefore not surprised that Spinoza's striving to build philosophy on the idea of the absolute being leads us to such difficulties as how the fundamental being, its unity undiminished, can appear in a plurality of fundamental forms, and what significance these have for it and for one another. The riddle of life and existence meets us ever anew at the end of all the attempts the human mind has made, in its religious and speculative systems, to solve it.

Spinoza is the first to have developed a theory that helps us beyond the one-sidedness of spiritualism and of materialism, not by compromising, but by really thinking the matter through to the end and courageously drawing all the consequences. But just as his religious theory was not understood, and his pantheism was interpreted as atheism, so his psychophysical theory was not understood, and his monism was interpreted as materialism. And even if one does not go so far, it is still often pointed out as an

[22] This I hope in years to come to be able to demonstrate in a separate work.

inconsistency in Spinoza that he sees the matter rather much from the bodily side, when, for example, he teaches that the perfection of consciousness depends on the perfection of the corresponding body. But it lies in the nature of the case that we are obliged to begin with the bodily when we wish to compare the different stages of mental life. With *[99]* the exception of our own consciousness we know mental life only through the bodily as intermediate link, and find it everywhere bound up with this. And what is the main thing: our knowledge of the bodily can reach a perfection and exactness that the knowledge of the mental will never reach. One has the surest starting point, therefore, when one begins with the bodily. That on Spinoza's conception the matter could nevertheless just as well be seen from the other side is shown by a proposition such as this one (Et. V, 1): "Just as the thoughts and representations are ordered and connected in consciousness, exactly so are the states of the body ordered and connected in the body." No connection of thoughts can take place without a connection of bodily motions taking place at the same time (the modern expression would be: molecular motions in the brain). Therefore it is no breach of the theory either when Spinoza shows how man can attain mastery over his drives and spiritual freedom. To the higher and the lower within the life of consciousness there naturally correspond different combinations of bodily processes. Modern physiology shows us, in the relation between higher and lower nerve centers, in the way in which the former can regulate the latter, a parallel to the psychological-ethical opposition between thought and drive ("the spirit" and "the flesh"). The objection mentioned would not so often have been raised against Spinoza if people had remembered his doctrine of the fundamental forms as each by itself infinite, so that there are bodily forms that correspond to the highest mental functions, as well as mental forms that correspond to *[100]* the simplest bodily motions, and if they had at the same time considered the matter from a physiological point of view. Spinoza refers expressly to involuntary actions (instinctive actions, somnambulism, etc.) and finds in them, like modern psychology, a hint toward the understanding of voluntary motions. It is the idea of connection, of continuity, that here too leads his thought to a happy stroke.

Before we leave this point in Spinoza's doctrine, it must be brought out that he does not always express himself clearly and consistently here. As an example of a certain material form and the corresponding thought being one and the same, he cites in one place (*Et. II, 7. Schol.*) the circle existing in nature and the concept of the circle. This

example is also constantly cited in expositions of Spinoza's philosophy. But I cannot believe otherwise than that Spinoza has here been guilty of a momentary confusion and lack of clarity. The relation between the actual circle and the concept of the circle is a relation between object and subject, not between matter and consciousness. The form within the attribute of extension that corresponds to a certain form within the attribute of thought is not that which is thought and represented, but the material motion (brain process) that coincides with the thinking activity. When we represent an object to ourselves, this happens, says Spinoza, through another body affecting our body and producing a certain state in it: our representation of the external object is then the form of
[101] thought that corresponds to the state into which our body comes through being affected by the other body. Our consciousness perceives no external body as actually existing except through the representations of the states of our own body, and therefore the states of our body can be called images of things, although they do not reproduce their figure. To my representation of the table there corresponds within the attribute of extension—not the table, but—the state into which my body (in particular the brain) is put by being affected by the table. To the concept of the circle there corresponds in the same way the material motion (in the brain) that takes place when I think the circle.—What occasioned the skew in the example cited from Spinoza is no doubt his strange usage in calling the human body the *object* of human consciousness. The bodily process that corresponds to the process of consciousness has, as the history of anatomy and physiology shows, only very late and by many detours begun to become an object for consciousness, and immediate consciousness perhaps has no inkling at all that such a material process is necessary. Although the two problems—of the relation between subject and object and of the relation between consciousness and matter—touch each other and pass over into each other, it is nevertheless important not to confuse them. The speculative philosophy in Germany, which at the beginning of this century renewed Spinozism, undertook precisely the essential change of putting subject and object throughout in place of consciousness
[102] and matter, and precisely thereby acquired an abstract, logical-idealistic character, which opened the way for many fantasies. Schelling declared Spinoza's philosophy to be "one-sided realism"; but what we miss in Schelling himself and in his whole school is precisely Spinoza's brilliant eye for, and deep respect for, the real, lawful connection of things.

III.

To every thought there corresponds, according to Spinoza's doctrine, a bodily motion. *[103]* But the motions in our body do not arise of themselves; they are called forth by motions proceeding from other bodies. Our body cannot exist at all unless it is constantly regenerated by influences from other bodies. From this it further follows that the state in which our body finds itself at any given moment is determined not merely by its own nature, but by the nature of the other bodies that affect it. The thoughts that correspond to the various bodily states and motions are therefore expressions not merely of the nature of our own body, but also of that of several other bodies. Thus arise what we call sensuous representations *(imaginationes)*. We suppose we have in them images of things; but they correspond only to the way in which our body is affected by things. We therefore often imagine that we have sense perceptions of things that are not present to us, since our body can be brought by inner causes into the same state as by outer causes. The mistake we thereby make springs from the fact that no other representation arises in us that excludes the presence of the object supposedly perceived. Error is thus something negative and consists in the lack of other representations that could convince us that the *[104]* object is not present. One who does not know the nature of the horse may very well believe that he sees a winged horse, and have no doubt about its reality.[23]

When two or more bodies have affected our body at the same time, consciousness, when it later perceives one of them, will also come to think of the other. On this rests memory, a connection or linking among representations, which forms itself in consciousness in accordance with the order and connection of the bodily states. In this connection we have no knowledge of the nature of things; it is of a purely subjective nature. That is why it will also be different representations that are connected in this way in different men. When a soldier sees hoofprints in the sand, he thinks at once of a rider, then of war, etc.; in a peasant, on the other hand, the representation of the horse leads to that of a plow, a field, etc. The connections depend on how each is accustomed to see things follow one another.—This law, the law of the association of ideas, Spinoza calls in one place a mental law of nature, a counterpart to the physical laws of motion.

[23]This theory agrees entirely with modern psychology. Taine has given it epigrammatic expression in the definition: la sensation est une hallucination vraie. Yet this way of seeing had already been put forward earlier by the able but little-known inquirer *Louis Peisse*.

There are thus laws in the mental as well as in the bodily domain. The doctrine of the associations of ideas had shortly before Spinoza been developed in clear and concise form
[105] by the Englishman Thomas Hobbes; but Spinoza is one of the older authors who have treated this important psychological doctrine in the most acute way, and who have seen its great and far-reaching significance, as will appear when we come to his doctrine of the passions. If Spinoza had been better known in England, he would surely have been named as one of the most important forerunners of modern English psychology.

As long as the sensuous representations and the associations of ideas prevail, we behave passively and reach no real knowledge. No representation and no association of ideas can be explained from our own nature alone. They always correspond, after all, to the way in which our body is or has been affected by other bodies, and can therefore be understood only when one takes into account all these bodies and their interaction. If we keep to the human mind alone, sense perceptions and associations of ideas are consequences without premises. The human being is only one link in an infinite series and cannot be understood unless one takes into account the other links of the series. Or, to see the matter from its highest point of view: a perfect (adequate) knowledge of external bodies is not found in God insofar as he is considered as expressed in the human mind alone, but only insofar as he is at the same time considered as expressed in many other beings.

As long as we remain at this stage of knowledge, we reach only a confused and incomplete knowledge, depending on the accidental way in which things affect us. This
[106] first kind of knowledge, which Spinoza designates as opinion or sensuous representation (imagination), has no other sources than what one hears from others or happens to experience *(experientia vaga)*. The essence of things constantly escapes us here; it is only their outer forms and relations that we can perceive. But the outer forms and relations of things depend on their inner essence, and so the task is to find a kind of knowledge that can give us access to this.

It is characteristic of Spinoza that he leaves the method of experience in such great haste and does not examine whether the defects from which it seems at first glance to suffer might not be remedied. Its imperfection consists, according to Spinoza, in its seeing things from the standpoint of the particular being, which is nevertheless only one link in the series. But it has been precisely the whole endeavor of modern experimental inquiry

to get beyond this isolated and accidental element in the starting point, and with what success it has striven for this, the history of natural science bears brilliant witness. Bacon already strove to formulate a method that reached beyond *experientia vaga*. That one can reach general laws by the path of induction Spinoza himself has furnished proof; for it is precisely by this path that he came to set up his doctrine of the degrees of individuality in nature, his theory of knowledge, his psychology, his politics. That in his theory of method he stands so far from modern inquiry has its ground in his speculative starting point, which in turn is an expression of his yearning to grasp the absolute, what is in itself, which cannot be given in any experience.—On the other hand it might seem as if precisely Spinoza's fundamental view should have led him to lay a weight of principle *[107]* on the method of experience and on the apprehension of the particular and finite. When dualism is rejected, and everything in nature is seen as a form of expression of one fundamental being, then knowledge of the reality given in experience also becomes a knowledge of the infinite itself, of the fundamental being. Spinoza therefore also says in one place: "Knowledge of the effect is one with a more perfect knowledge of the cause. We therefore cannot gain insight into nature without at the same time extending our knowledge of the first cause." But Spinoza, like Descartes, conceives the right method as the one that starts from the highest cause. Acquaintance with what is given in experience acquires only the significance of directing our thought toward certain definite things. Knowledge of the essence of things itself must be drawn from another source.

The second kind of knowledge is raised above the isolated and subjective standpoint that was the imperfection of sensuous representation (imagination). All bodies have something in common: they all belong under the same attribute, and the general laws of motion hold for them all. Of this common element there can be a perfect knowledge; for it does not merely express the state or nature of the particular individual, but the knowledge of it is universally valid. By grasping the general and lawful connection of things man raises himself above the accidentalness and externality of the imagination. This knowledge does not concern something that holds only for a certain definite point in time, any more than for a particular thing, but something that holds without regard to time. To see things in their lawful connection is thus to see them under the aspect of *[108]* eternity. The necessity of things is one with the necessity in God's own nature: God, after all, produces everything in producing himself. Things here lose their outer independence

of one another; we know that the power by which each of them persists in its existence follows from the natural necessity in God's essence. We can thus consider things as actual in two different ways: either so that we consider them as existing at a certain point in time and at a certain place in space—which is the way of looking of the imagination, the first kind of knowledge—or so that we see them as contained in God and following from the necessity of the divine nature—and this is the second kind of knowledge, which Spinoza calls reason (ratio).

The more man considers things as accidental, the more he is himself subject to accident. What we learn by sense perception and by tradition is not in our own control. On the other hand, the clear and distinct concepts we form depend solely on our nature and its fixed and determinate laws. With regard to these concepts we need fetch no confirmation and corroboration from outside: truth and certainty coincide. With the true idea there immediately comes the certainty of its truth. Just as light helps us to distinguish between light and darkness, so it is truth by whose help we discover what is untrue *(verum est index sui et falsi)*. Doubt, untruth and fancy arise only through our considering things in a confused way and not forming distinct and clear concepts by
[109] going back to the simple elements and the general laws. The idea of a square circle is confused; for as soon as one goes to its elements, the concept of circle and the concept of square, one sees at once that they cannot be combined in this way. And in any case a false and invented idea will soon show itself in its untruth if we only carefully draw all its consequences.

To grasp rightly what Spinoza means by rational knowledge, it is necessary to distinguish between the common and the abstract. Rational knowledge has as its object the general laws of things and thereby the essence of things. The laws that spring from the essence of things hold for the whole as well as for each particular part and are thus expressions of the unity in everything. They correspond to the concept of attributes or fundamental forms, which are, after all, each by itself one with substance or the fundamental being; each time we consider a body according to the general law of extension, or a thought according to the general law of thinking, we conceive them as expressions and forms of the fundamental being.—Abstract concepts, on the other hand, are formed, according to Spinoza, by the imagination or the sensuous mode of representation and depend on a confused apprehension of a multitude of particulars. Here belong all general

concepts, which are really schematic images that arise in us when we have often had representations of bodily objects (horses, men, etc.) and these representations now, as it were, grind off their differences, so that there remains only that in which they all agree. Each man forms these general concepts in his own way, according to the features of the objects that have particularly made an impression on him.—The difference between the abstract and the common thus consists in this, that the former gives an indistinct *[110]* schema, the latter a clear and distinct knowledge of law and, in the knowledge of law, a knowledge of what works in everything. In true knowledge our thoughts follow the eternal order of things; our mind is an *automaton spirituale*, whose working follows the same laws as the divine nature.

Spinoza's model in describing this form of knowledge is the mathematical-mechanical conception of nature. He would have set up a closer relation between the first and the second forms of knowledge if he had had greater sympathy for, and clearer understanding of, the experimental method. For the path by which one arrives at the application of the mathematical method in natural science is exact experimentation, which makes quantitative determinations possible.—Rational knowledge concerns, after all, laws and relations generally; but the elements, the actual existences, between which these relations obtain and for which the laws hold, we can know only by experience. As shown earlier, the very concepts of attribute and substance have sprung from analysis of what is given in experience.—Here again we see that there is not, as Spinoza thought, any complete opposition or any sharp boundary between empirical knowledge and rational knowledge.

But rational knowledge still has for Spinoza the unsatisfactory feature that it is discursive in character, draws conclusions from a general law to the particular cases. To illustrate the relation between the kinds of knowledge he uses the following comparison. When three numbers are given, and a fourth is to be found that is related to the third *[111]* as the second is related to the first, the person who has merely learned the rule of three multiplies the second and third numbers together and divides the product by the first. His knowledge is purely empirical, rests on tradition and experience, and thus belongs under the first kind of knowledge. The person who knows mathematics, on the other hand, performs the same operation because it is an application of the doctrine of proportions. This corresponds to the second kind of knowledge. But when the numbers are very simple, one need perform no operation at all. One can, e.g., see immediately that 1 is

related to 2 as 3 to 6. The general rule here becomes superfluous; in place of calculation and reasoning there appears immediate intuition of the relation; in place of the discursive, the intuitive.

The third and highest form of knowledge is intuitive knowledge. It beholds the essence of things immediately, without the help of general propositions. As an example of such intuitive knowledge Spinoza cites the fact that when we know something, we thereby also have an immediate knowledge of what it is to know. In the first book of the "Ethics" he has, by his own account, employed the second form of knowledge. He there set up a series of definitions and axioms and derived from them his doctrine that everything, as regards both essence and existence, depends on the fundamental being. Only at the end of the "Ethics" (in the fifth book) does this doctrine become the object of intuitive knowledge, as the human mind immediately sees itself as an element in the
[112] fundamental being. Here we no longer have general rules, but an immediate beholding of the inner connection of the particular with the whole.

In the "Short Treatise" this highest form of knowledge is described in expressions that have a certain mystical and religious stamp. We are thereby reminded of the original practical motive of Spinoza's thinking. "Rational inference is not what is most excellent in us, but is only like a ladder by which we climb up to the desired point, or like a good spirit that, without falsehood and deceit, brings us word of the highest good, in order thereby to urge us to seek it and unite ourselves with it, which union is our highest welfare and happiness." "That this [third] kind of knowledge is not a consequence of something else, but is immediate, is evident from the fact that God is the cause of all knowledge and is known only through himself, not through anything else, and from the fact that we are by nature so united with him that without him we can neither exist nor be understood. From this close union between God and us it follows that he can only be understood immediately."—The way in which we thus immediately apprehend the fundamental being or the Deity is designated partly as an immediate revelation to the understanding, partly as a feeling and enjoyment of things in themselves.—In his later writings too Spinoza designates the third form of knowledge as the highest virtue and the highest blessedness.

There is this difficulty in Spinoza's description of the third form of knowledge, that in some places he describes it as an altogether immediate intuition, but in other places

determines it as a movement of thought that goes from the knowledge of the fundamental *[113]*
forms to the knowledge of the essence of things, or as a knowledge of the thing through its proximate cause. With this latter determination it does not become quite different from rational knowledge, above which it is nevertheless supposed to be raised; it involuntarily shows its kinship with it, just as we saw above a natural kinship between rational knowledge and empirical knowledge, which were not so foreign to each other either as Spinoza supposed.

The motive for seeking beyond rational knowledge we shall easily find if we recall Spinoza's fundamental concept and its definition: "Substance is that which is in itself and is conceived through itself, i.e., that whose concept does not need the concept of any other thing from which it would have to be formed." If a concept is to be apprehended in and through itself, without the use of other concepts, then it is clear that no operation of thought or inference can take place. Where should the movement of thought go when there is only one concept? What is understood "in and through itself" is an object of beholding, not of thinking. Spinoza therefore could not hold fast to his concept of substance without setting up a form of knowledge different from ordinary experience and thinking and raised above them. The same holds of all the philosophers who have maintained a direct and positive knowledge of the absolute. For Plato the highest knowledge was "a beholding of the best of what is," namely of "the first, presuppositionless ground of everything." Presuppositionless, after all, Spinoza's substance too is supposed to be. But what is to be altogether without presuppositions cannot be thought; it must be intuited. Schelling carried this to an extreme in his doctrine of "intellectual intuition," which is an *[114]*
immediate apprehension of the absolute as the eternal unity of subject and object, of all oppositions. This intuition was for Schelling a special organ, which one either had or did not have. Those who lacked it simply lacked the condition for philosophizing, just as one who could not construct and intuit figures in space would lack the condition for being a mathematician.—Just as speculative philosophy must appeal to a special organ when it wishes to maintain a positive knowledge of the absolute, so is it also the case with positive religion and theology. These too point beyond experience and thinking to a higher source of knowledge. Through rebirth and faith access is opened to a higher nature than that which is accessible to the unbeliever.—We see here again how speculative philosophy is reminiscent of the positive-religious consciousness. When philosophy, on the other hand,

acknowledges the law of relativity and carries it through completely, it must give up the appeal to a special source of knowledge and place itself on an equal footing with all other scientific inquiry. Science, like all culture, originally unfolded under the protecting cover of religion, and philosophy still displays many marks and remnants of this husk. It will no doubt also cast them off, and it will be able to do so without injuring any real human interest.

This is not to say that the idea of an intuitive knowledge is to be rejected entirely. The error consists only in regarding it as a special source of knowledge. The development of
[115] knowledge does not reach its peak in mere reasoning. Everyone knows that one has fully made a piece of knowledge one's own only when one can skip or survey all, or at any rate many, of the intermediate determinations and see the whole connection at a single glance. Intuition, or intellectual seeing, is thus a natural result of effort and practice with scientific trains of thought. In this sense it holds that intuitive knowledge alone is the crown of our labor of knowledge. But it then stands in the closest connection with the other stages of knowledge and grows forth from them in a natural way, just as good habits and instincts grow forth from the efforts of the will. Spinoza's own example mentioned above points in this direction. For that 1 is related to 2 as 3 to 6 is seen immediately only by one who is practiced in operating with numbers; the child who does not yet know his multiplication table must first laboriously work his way up to such an intuition. —

There is a class of concepts to which Spinoza denies absolute validity because they suffer from the imperfections peculiar to the first kind of knowledge. They are such concepts as good and evil, beautiful and ugly, order and disorder, purposiveness, etc., when they are applied to the essence of things. The imperfection of the imagination or sensuous representation consisted, after all, in its considering everything from man's individual and accidental standpoint and measuring everything by this. Man from the outset judges everything practically, regards all things around him as means and tools, and calls good what he can use, evil what harms and hinders him. He thus accustoms
[116] himself first and foremost to ask, of every thing he sees, what it serves for, instead of how it came into being. When he has then learned that the eyes are for seeing with, plants and animals for eating, the sun for giving light, he has explanation enough. From this stems the notion of the purposiveness of nature. Now on the other hand there is much that is harmful and pernicious in nature; this, people then suppose, is due to

the wrath of the gods over men's sins. And when experience shows that misfortunes strike good men just as well as bad, it is declared that the counsels of the gods surpass human comprehension. Instead of remedying one's ignorance, one thus appeals to it as an argument. If mathematics had not shown men another rule of truth, the human race would have remained in its ignorance. But the old prejudices are still so strong that one who seeks scientific insight into nature, instead of persisting in foolish wonder, is regarded as impious.—Just as men ascribe ends to nature according to their own wishes, so they also find order and disorder, beauty and ugliness in nature, according as things are easy or difficult to intuit and apprehend, appeal to their power of apprehension or not. But these concepts, and in general all concepts of perfection and imperfection, spring from comparisons that we make, and assert nothing about nature in itself. We form a general concept, a certain type, that fits all individuals of a certain kind, and the more the particular individual approaches this type, the more perfect we say it is. But this general concept, this type, belongs to our understanding, and not to nature. The infinite *[117]* being that we call God or nature acts with the same necessity with which it exists. Our concepts of perfection and imperfection therefore cannot be applied to it. Only when one understands by perfection reality, being, can this concept be applied to nature; perfection then extends just as far as the true being of things. But limitation belongs only to the finite, not to the infinite being. When we find imperfection in nature, it is thus only because we consider it from a finite point of view: in itself everything is perfect, when one does not set it over against something else with which one compares it, i.e., when one does not consider it as finite. Nature does not act according to the law of human reason and does not direct itself according to human purposes and wishes, but according to infinitely many other laws that spring from the eternal order of nature, in which man is only a single link. When something therefore seems to us ridiculous, absurd or evil, it comes from our limited knowledge. What our reason declares evil is evil only according to the laws of *our* nature, not according to the order and law of *the whole of* nature. One who strives for knowledge of the true essence of things will not blame or mock anything in nature, because he knows that everything happens according to the eternal and necessary laws of the divine nature.

If aesthetic and ethical concepts cannot be applied to nature in itself, because they arise only through comparisons and valuations that we make from our finite standpoint,

[118] then the same would seem to have to hold for still more concepts, and Spinoza saw this too. As we have already seen, time, number and measure are determinations that do not hold for true being. Time is not a determination of things themselves, but merely a mode of representation in us by which we determine the duration of a thing's existence. But in God there is nothing earlier or later; his existence—and thus all existence—is a necessary or eternal consequence of his essence.

This way of looking at things ought surely to have been applied to all other concepts as well. Spinoza would have done so had he not, as a good dogmatist, believed in the possibility of our being able to come to consider things from another point of view than our own. Such concepts as substance and cause, which Spinoza applies without hesitation to the absolute, will on closer consideration also prove to be relative. Yet it is remarkable to see to how high a degree Spinoza has succeeded in emancipating himself from anthropomorphism. The naive view applies all determinations and concepts to things without further ado. Modern philosophy has in its successive development been led to refer all these concepts back to human consciousness and to see them as symbols that express existence from a definite point of view, without our having in them the only possible solution of the great riddle. Spinoza has often been sharply reproached for his doctrine that concepts such as good and evil do not hold for the essence of things and have only relative validity. In this, however, he is quite within his rights. His treatment
[119] of aesthetic and ethical concepts is a necessary consequence of Copernicus's astronomy and of Galilæi's and Descartes's physics. When the earth is no longer the center of the universe, man cannot be so either, and his judgments hold only from a point of view that is vanishingly small in relation to the great, infinite whole. And when everything in nature is subject to the laws of mathematical mechanics, one cannot explain its phenomena by inserting ideal forces. What must be objected to Spinoza is, on the contrary, that he has not gone far enough, and further, that he in part assumes that the relativity of concepts is equivalent to their invalidity. That this is not so he in reality grants himself, as regards the ethical concepts, for in his ethical doctrine he sets up "an ideal pattern of human nature" and calls good what brings us nearer this pattern, evil what removes us from it. If such a type really expresses human life as it would be, according to its natural laws, if it reached its highest possible development, then it and the other ethical concepts attached to it have all the validity that can be demanded, and this validity suffers no impairment

from our not being able to decide what significance this ideal and our striving for its realization have for the universe as a whole.[24]

IV.

It is a quite common prejudice that an ethics is altogether impossible on the basis of *[120]* determinism. When a philosopher conceives human feelings and actions as subject to laws of nature, a certain kind of criticism is at once ready with the remark that only by a happy inconsistency can he set up an ethics, a doctrine of the ends of human action and of the means of attaining them. Without absolutely free will, it is said, no ethics. On closer consideration one will easily see on which side the "happy inconsistency" lies. Ethics would be impossible precisely if there were an absolutely free will in man; then every coherent doctrine of human action would be impossible. The chain could be broken at any moment. Of definite ends grounded in human nature, and of definite means for their realization, there could then be no question. Spinoza was therefore, precisely as a determinist, well fitted to set forth an ethical doctrine. In thorough psychological knowledge of human nature and its laws there is hardly any ethicist who comes near him; and if ethics is to be grounded in the laws of human nature, thorough psychology is the first condition for an ethicist. It is another matter that ethics, like every investigation *[121]* of the development and laws of individual beings, acquires a significance of principle in Spinoza's system only insofar as the experimental undercurrent is able to assert itself against the speculative overcurrent that has its expression in Spinoza's fundamental thought, the concept of substance. If one starts from this concept alone, ethical development, like all concrete and finite development, becomes inexplicable and illusory. But if we take both currents in Spinozism, as they already manifest themselves in the first axiom in the first book of the Ethics (see above, p. 87), then Spinoza is fully consistent in setting up an ethical doctrine.

Spinoza maintains repeatedly and with great energy that human feelings and passions are to be investigated with the same calm and impartiality as other natural phenomena. "Most of those," he says in the preface to the third book of the "Ethics," "who have written about the passions and about men's way of life seem to speak not of natural phenomena

[24] Compare my work "Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik." Kbhvn. 1876, P. 84–86.

that follow the common laws of nature, but of things that stand outside nature. They seem to regard man in nature as a state within the state. For they believe that man disturbs the order of nature rather than follows it, and that he has absolute power over his actions and cannot be determined from anywhere but himself. Nature is everywhere the same and everywhere one; its power and efficacy, i.e., the laws and rules of nature according to which everything happens and passes over from one form to another, are everywhere and always the same, and there is therefore only one way in which the nature of any
[122] thing whatever can be understood, namely through the laws and universal rules of nature. The passions of hatred, anger and envy therefore spring in themselves from the same necessity and power of nature as other finite things; they have definite causes through which they are explained, and definite properties that are just as worthy of our knowledge as the properties of any other thing whose contemplation delights us. I shall therefore treat of the nature and powers of the passions, and of the mind's power over them, by the same method I have used in what precedes, and I shall consider human actions and drives in the same way as I consider lines, planes and bodies." In the introduction to his Political Treatise Spinoza likewise declares that he will treat these questions with the same freedom of mind that we bring to mathematical investigations. "I have earnestly endeavored not to mock, lament or curse human actions, but to understand them, and I have therefore considered the human passions, love, hatred, anger, envy, ambition, pity and the other emotions, not as faults of human nature, but as properties that belong to it, just as heat, cold, storm, thunder and the like belong to the nature of the air, which, to be sure, bring inconveniences but are nevertheless necessary and have definite causes through which we strive to understand their nature, an understanding that brings the mind just as much joy as the knowledge of the things that bring pleasant consequences
[123] for us."—These words have sometimes been cited with a shudder and regarded as signs of a cold and heartless way of thinking. To this it need only be said that if a psychology at all—a knowledge of the laws of mental life—is to be possible, then one must conceive mental phenomena as pure objects of knowledge, without any feeling other than the wish to understand and explain them as well as possible. No inquiry is possible without the inquirer's frame of mind, and this frame of mind is driven out as soon as aesthetic and moral feelings assert themselves. Precisely because Spinoza saw this so clearly, and because this inquirer's frame of mind was the prevailing one in him, he has become one

of the most important forerunners of modern scientific psychology.

Kuno Fischer has aptly shown how Spinoza here accomplished for philosophy what Shakespeare before him had already accomplished in poetry: "Every real character has its passions, and every passion has its necessary course of development, which is dramatic because it consists in definite actions; every true drama is nothing but the natural history of human passions.—In philosophy Spinoza was the first who grasped this truth and proved it with reasons; but the world-historical merit of having first of all discovered dramatic human life in this sense belongs to an earlier mind. Beyond philosophy, on the border between two ages, rises the gigantic Shakespeare, to whose poetic intuition it first became clear that the events of the human world proceed from actions, actions from passions, passions from characters, and characters from the natural and historical *[124]* connection of things.—Man acts in Shakespeare's imagination and in Spinoza's philosophy as a nature that fulfills its law, and passion, which moves human power and drives it forward, knows only one way, the way of the stream to the fall."—Kuno Fischer further points out that Shakespeare and Spinoza celebrated their resurrection at the same time and among the same circle of men. It was Lessing in particular who drew them both forth again and paved the way for their understanding. (Geschichte der neuern Philosophie. I. Mannheim 1854. P. 416–420).[25]

Spinoza's doctrine of the passions (the affects), which forms the groundwork of his ethical doctrine, can be understood only if one starts from his doctrine of the individual being. Each individual being is a finite form of the infinite fundamental being; all individual beings stand in interaction with one another and together form the great individual of nature. Insofar as the individual being is affected and determined by the other individual beings, it is restricted, limited and passive. That is why it is only in part the cause of the effects that proceed from it. A complete (adequate) cause an individual being would be only if the effect could be explained entirely from its nature alone. We are said to act when we are complete causes, but to suffer when we are incomplete causes. By affect or passion we understand a state (affection) by which our power of action is increased or diminished, and at the same time the representation of this state. *[125]* The passion is of an active character when we ourselves are the complete cause of the

[25] In the preface to his first work *Taine* refers to Spinoza, and this reference is characteristic of the famous critic's whole standpoint and method.

state, but of a passive character when we ourselves are only in part the cause. —It is thus as a link in the series of natural beings that man is subject to passive passions. He can no more than any other individual being withdraw himself from the influence of external causes. The passions arise through the clash between the working of external causes and the individual being's own fundamental drive. Every thing strives, insofar as it has existence in itself, to go on existing. Only external causes can abolish a thing's existence; insofar as it depends on the thing alone, it will go on existing. This drive of self-preservation is in itself nothing other than human nature itself, from which there follows with necessity *that* which serves for its preservation, so that man is naturally determined to seek it.—Spinoza seems here to have transferred the law of inertia from the bodily to the mental domain. Galilæi, and after him Kepler and Descartes, had shown that a body will remain in its state (of rest or motion) when the influence of other bodies does not bring it out of it. This law Spinoza now regards as a universal law, not restricted to physical bodies. In itself, too, it is only a form of the universal principle of causality, which demands a definite cause for every change. For Spinoza this generalization lay near at hand. All individual beings are finite forms of the fundamental being, and the power of the fundamental being works in them. The individual being is, to be sure, finite
[126] and limited, but as a form of the fundamental being it has a share in its independence. "The power of natural things to exist and to act can be none other than the eternal power of God." "Although each thing is determined by another particular thing to exist in a certain way, yet the power by which each thing persists in its existence follows from the eternal necessity of God's nature."

The passion now arises through this fundamental drive being checked or furthered in its working. When the mind, owing to external influences, passes over to a greater power of thought, joy arises; when it passes over to a lesser power of thought, sorrow arises. Desire, joy and sorrow are the three most original passions, from which all others spring. The laws according to which they develop are the laws of the association of ideas. When joy is accompanied by the representation of the cause that has called it forth, love arises. When sorrow is accompanied by the representation of its cause, hatred arises. The mind seeks as far as possible to hold fast what increases and furthers its power of action, and turns away from what checks it. The one who loves therefore necessarily strives to have the beloved object present and to preserve it, whereas the one who hates

seeks to remove and destroy the object of his hatred.[26]

When we have had two passions at once, then, if the one of them arises again, we *[127]* shall also come to feel the other. In this way any thing can indirectly become a cause of joy, sorrow or desire, namely when the feeling the thing itself calls forth awakens another feeling, which we therefore often cannot explain ourselves, because we have forgotten the original connection between the two feelings. Many inexplicable sympathies and antipathies have this origin.—One and the same thing can call forth mixed feelings, since it is directly the cause of one feeling, indirectly of another.

Because of the property of love that it binds the lover and the beloved object into a whole, the feelings of the beloved object will also arise in the lover. Love thus becomes like an extension of our being, through which new causes of feelings of various kinds arise. What awakens joy or sorrow in the beloved object will call forth love or hatred in the lover.—Sorrow brought about by the misfortune of others is pity, whereas Spinoza missed a word in the language to express joy at the good fortune of others. Love toward one who does good to another is called favor *(favor)*; hatred toward one who has inflicted evil on another, indignation *(indignatio)*.—On the other hand we feel love toward one who inflicts evil on someone we hate, and hatred toward one who does him good.

When we imagine that someone loves, desires or hates something that we ourselves love, desire or hate, we shall thereby come to love, desire or hate it still more, whereas *[128]* we shall feel a wavering of mind *(animi fluctuatio)* when we imagine that he abhors what we desire, or the reverse. Everyone will therefore by nature strive that the others come to live according to his mind. And since all now strive for this, they hinder one another in equal measure. Everyone wants to be praised or loved by all others, and therefore all hate one another. Ambition therefore becomes the strongest of all passions; it draws nourishment from many sides. It seeks the approval of men, but on the other hand also wants all to approve what it itself approves.

The thought that a being resembling us, toward which we have no preconceived feeling, has some feeling or other awakens the same feeling in us. For insofar as the other

[26] Descartes had (in his Traité des passions) defined love as the will to unite oneself with the beloved object in such a way that together with it one forms a whole. Spinoza objects to this definition that it expresses, to be sure, an essential property of love, but not the essence of love itself.—A similar remark is made by Socrates in Plato's "Symposium" on the occasion of Aristophanes's mythical account of how men in love seek their original other half.

being is like us, it comes to the same thing whether we imagine it in a certain state or we imagine ourselves in the same state. We rejoice and grieve with others merely because they are beings like us. Even the downfall of our enemy therefore awakens sorrow in us, because he was a man like us. Here further belongs all involuntary imitation, as when one draws back one's hand because one sees another burn himself. By the same law another's joy in an object awakens our desire for it, and we seek to deprive him of the object. So it goes with human nature, that we pity those who fare ill and envy those who fare well. Compassion, envy and ambition spring from one and the same property of
[129] human nature. This one will especially find confirmed when one observes man in the first years of his life. The child cries and laughs according as it sees others cry and laugh, and it feels desire for what it sees others rejoice in and desire. The role that envy and ambition play in human life is nourished by upbringing, since parents especially make use of these passions to spur children on to virtue.

In each particular case the passion acquires a different character according to the particular object that awakens it, and according to the peculiarity of the individual in whom it arises. One and the same individual is affected differently by different objects; the same object affects different individuals differently, and one and the same individual differently at different times. The passion is, after all, nothing but the very nature of the individual being, and the essence of the particular, definite passion depends on how it is affected by other individual beings, other links in the chain of nature.

Through the combination and interaction of the various passions a multitude of derived passions can arise. They form with the same necessity as the original passions. We are set in motion in many ways by external causes and tossed about like the waves of the sea driven by different winds, without knowing our goal and outcome. —

Spinoza's account of the origin and development of the passions is not only characteristic of his intellectual direction and his standpoint, of his search for the necessary connection in everything, but is also in itself a model of psychological investigation and
[130] has great lasting value. In the psychological literature of the Continent this account is still unsurpassed; England, on the other hand, has in Hobbes, Hartley, Hume and in our time especially Bain a series of men who have treated the same subject by the same method as Spinoza and can be placed beside him.

The basic determination of joy and sorrow (pleasure and pain) from which Spinoza

starts agrees entirely with that of modern psychology. Joy, he says, is[27] transition to greater, sorrow to lesser perfection; and he points out expressly that joy is not perfection itself, nor sorrow imperfection itself. "For if man were born with the perfection to which he passes over, he would possess it without the feeling of joy. This shows itself still more clearly in sorrow. That sorrow consists in the transition to lesser perfection, not in the lesser perfection itself, no one can deny, since man cannot grieve insofar as he partakes of any perfection."—We have here the law of relativity in its application to the domain of feelings. Pleasure and pain we feel only through a change in our state, an advance or a decline in a certain respect. Yet they do not consist, as Spinoza likewise expressly stresses, in a comparison between the two states that succeed each other. Such a comparison would lead us beyond the domain of feeling to the purely intellectual.—We shall see, however, that Spinoza's psychology suffers precisely from the one-sidedness *[131]* that this difference between the various expressions of mental life is not held fast, since the intellectual side really becomes, in him, everything.

Pleasure and pain arise through advance and decline in our being, and our being Spinoza sees as active, as striving for self-assertion—a finite form of the infinite fundamental power working in everything, which is cause of itself. This is reminiscent of the fundamental biological law that has been stated and carried through in our day in so brilliant a way, and that sees life as a struggle for existence. Spinoza has predecessors in this conception—not only in Descartes and the other physicists who set up the law of inertia—but also in Thomas Hobbes, who built his whole ethical and political doctrine on the drive of self-preservation.—

We have so far considered only the passive passions, which arise in man through influences from outside and therefore cannot be explained entirely from his own nature alone, since the nature of the external surroundings plays an essential part as well. But passion is not always of a passive nature, although the Danish term [*Lidenskab*, from *lide*, to suffer] takes account of that alone.[28] Besides the joy and desire that are of a passive kind, there are other feelings of joy and desire that belong to us as acting beings.

Our power of action coincides for Spinoza with our power of thought. He sees the essence of the mind in thought (just as he sees the essence of matter in extension); the *[132]*

[27] It would have been more correct to say "arises through" instead of "is." These simple psychical phenomena can be defined only by what calls them forth.

[28] Spinoza's general term is *affectus*, and this can be either passio or actio.

decision or act of will is for him only the assent to and affirmation of the truth known. But thought is not a mute picture; it is activity and life. One can act against a picture or a word that hovers before consciousness, but not against what has really become the mind's own property and what it has assented to. Intellect and will are one. We act insofar as we have adequate ideas, i.e., ideas that can be explained entirely from our own nature and are therefore clear and distinct. We suffer insofar as we have obscure and mutilated ideas, and this is the case when we are determined from outside. Our power of action or of thought can be increased or diminished. Sorrow is a sign that it is diminished, and therefore belongs to the passive feelings. Joy and desire, on the other hand, *can* be of an active nature.

All actions that belong to the mind as thinking spring from strength of mind *(fortitudo)*, which appears partly as courage *(animositas)*, partly as generosity *(generositas)*. Courage is the desire by which each strives to preserve his being according to the dictate of reason alone. By generosity Spinoza understands the desire by which each, according to the dictate of reason, strives to help other men and to join them to himself in friendship. Thus the actions that have the agent's own good in view belong under courage; those that also have the good of others in view, under generosity. To the first kind belong virtues such as temperance and presence of mind; to the latter kind modesty, mildness, etc.

[133] In the opposition between the suffering and the acting state, or between the obscurity and the clarity of thought, we have the starting point for an evaluation of the affects. Although the concepts good and evil do not designate anything positive in things themselves, they nevertheless acquire a relative significance for us, since we compare actual human nature with a pattern that we form of perfect human nature. Good we then call what brings us nearer this pattern, evil what removes us from it. Virtue is power—it is, namely, man's very nature, insofar as man is able to produce something that can be conceived through the laws of his nature alone. Independence, spiritual freedom, spiritual power is the essence of virtue, which, as said, appears partly as courage, partly as generosity.

Since man's essence consists in thought, the dictate of reason cannot be different from the fundamental drive itself. The source of passion was, after all, the individual being's striving to assert itself. But precisely this striving is the first and only foundation

of virtue. No principle can be conceived that should lie deeper than this striving, which is one with the very fundamental nature of the individual being. Each strives for what is useful to him. This striving is checked only by external causes and is in itself one with virtue. The dictate of reason is that each should seek his true advantage. Reason is nothing but our mind itself, insofar as it has a clear and distinct knowledge. Therefore the dictate of reason aims at nothing but knowledge, and striving for true knowledge is the only virtue. Our power and our freedom consist in true knowledge; we act, after *[134]* all, only when we have adequate ideas; otherwise we suffer. But the highest thing the mind grasps is God, the absolutely infinite being, without which nothing can be or be conceived. To develop one's knowledge is to know God, his attributes and his acting, which follow from his nature. Blessedness consists in the peace of mind that springs from the intuitive knowledge of God. The highest desire of one who is led by reason is the one that leads him to clear knowledge of himself and of all things that present themselves to his understanding. In this striving human nature finds its highest fulfillment. It develops here according to its own inner laws. No evil can therefore befall man except from external causes, or insofar as man is a part of nature and is affected by other parts. And this, as a finite being, he must necessarily be. But when other individual beings agree with his nature, they will be able to be a help to him in his striving. Nothing is so useful to us as what agrees entirely with our nature. When two individuals of the same nature are united with each other, they form an individual twice as great as the single individual. Man can wish for nothing better for the preservation of his being than that all should so agree in everything that they form, as it were, one mind and one body, and that all at once should seek the common advantage of all. Those who are led by reason therefore wish nothing for themselves that they do not also wish for other men.

Insofar as men are led by the passive passions, they differ from one another, and to that extent each individual man is also changeable and inconstant. When, on the *[135]* other hand, they are led by reason, they agree. Each then does what is good for human nature as a whole, and therefore also what agrees with the nature of each individual man. By seeking his own true advantage each individual thus furthers the advantage of others. The highest good, the knowledge of the eternal and the peace that follows from it, is common to all; no one is excluded from access to it. And the more each for himself becomes a partaker in this good, the more he will also wish to make others

partakers in it. Partly it is a psychological law that what we love gains still greater value for us when we see that others love it too; partly we shall be furthered in our striving when others strive with us. There is no way in which a man can better display what spiritual powers he commands than by educating others to live according to the dictate of their own reason. Moreover, only by united forces can men procure what they need and withstand dangers. Admittedly very few live according to the dictate of reason, but it holds nevertheless—despite all that satirists, melancholics and theologians object—that far more goods than evils spring from the social life of men.

From the standpoint now reached Spinoza judges the various passions. Joy is in and of itself good, since it is the expression of an advance in perfection. Sorrow, on the other hand, is in and of itself evil, since it signifies a decline. Everything we do should aim at advance and improvement. But as long as we grieve, we make ourselves unfit to act in
[136] this way: sorrow is a decline in the power of action.—Spinoza therefore evaluates many feelings in a way different from the usual one, and here in particular he enters into a characteristic opposition to the theological conception. From his clear insight into the necessary connection, and his faith that this necessary connection is one with the essence of the Deity, there had to follow an evaluation of various moods and feelings different from that of those who regard nature as corrupted by an original fall. In a statement of a more personal character than one otherwise finds in his writings, he says: "Only a savage and gloomy superstition can forbid joy. Why should one rather still hunger and thirst than drive away melancholy?—Thus I think, and thus the matter stands for me: No deity, and in general no one who is not envious, rejoices in my weakness and my misfortune, or regards tears, sobbing, fear and similar signs of weakness of mind as signs of virtue. On the contrary, the greater the joy we feel, the greater the perfection to which we pass over, and the more we share in the divine nature. The wise man will therefore use things and take delight in them, thus strengthening and refreshing himself with moderate and pleasant food and drink, with fragrances, beautiful green plants, fine dress, music, bodily exercise, the theater and other such things, which anyone can enjoy without harm to anyone else."

That hatred is evil follows of itself. It falls away with the knowledge that the endeavor to realize the human ideal excludes no one. Hatred is increased by reciprocal hatred, but
[137] is extinguished by love and generosity and itself passes over into a love that becomes

the greater the stronger the hatred has been.—Hope and fear are not good in themselves either. They are bound up with uncertainty and sorrow and are signs of uncertain and defective knowledge. One who is sure of his ground neither hopes nor fears.—Pity is in itself bad and useless in a man who lives according to the dictate of reason. Sorrow is bound up with pity, and the good that can spring from it springs also from the dictate of reason. One who has seen that everything follows from the necessity of the divine nature and happens according to the eternal laws and rules of nature will pity no one. Such a mood easily leads to actions that afterward prove to be wrong, and one will easily be deceived by false tears.—Humility and repentance are not virtues either, but signs of imperfection. Humility is a sorrow that arises from man's contemplating his own weakness, and repentance likewise rests only on man's seeing himself as powerless. None of these feelings can therefore be the motive of perfect action, which is to spring precisely from man's spiritual power. We come to the right way sooner by reason and love than by repentance and contrition. Only superstitious teachers, who understand better how to rail at vice than to preach virtue, who break men's minds instead of strengthening them, and who therefore would rather lead men by fear than by reason—only they can praise these feelings. The desire or drive of self-preservation that is one with man's rational nature is directed straight toward the good. Evil is avoided indirectly. When we follow *[138]* our true nature, we need food, to be sure, but not medicine. It is only the sick man who, from fear of death, takes medicine. But the free man thinks of nothing less than of death; his wisdom has life, not death, as its content.

Yet it is only when we speak of the man who is led by reason, of the spiritually free man, that this holds. One who is moved to help others neither by reason nor by pity is rightly called inhuman. And since men seldom live according to the dictate of reason, humility and repentance, hope and fear do more good than harm, and if one must err, one had better repent and fear too much than too little. If the irrational, spiritually unfree men were all equally arrogant, they would be ashamed of nothing and fear nothing, and nothing would be able to govern them. The prophets, who cared not for the advantage of a few men but for the common advantage, therefore zealously enjoined humility, repentance and reverence. And in reality those who are governed by these feelings can far more easily than others be led to live according to the dictate of reason, i.e., to be free and lead a blessed life.

Spinoza gives a series of means by which passion can be brought to become active instead of passive *(remedia affectuum)*. First and foremost, the task is to know the nature and cause of the passion; for as soon as it is known, it ceases to be a passive passion. All passive passions arise, after all, from our being parts of nature and therefore having only inadequate ideas; the passive therefore falls away with adequate knowledge. It is
[139] a common experience that sorrow is softened when one sees that the misfortune was necessary. Yet it is one and the same passion that first appears as passive and afterward as active. The ambitious and proud man endeavors just as much as the one who is led by reason that all should live according to his thoughts; but what the former desires from inadequate insight, the latter strives for with full and true knowledge.—Another important means is to separate the emotion or passion from the thought of the external cause and connect it with other thoughts. Love and hatred arose, after all, from joy and sorrow in connection with the thought of the things that caused these feelings; when this connection is dissolved again, the passion must thus also take on another character. We must use the intervals in which the passion is not raging to bring about and practice such a connection among the representations as reason requires, thus in particular to lead them all back to the highest thought, the idea of the Deity. Since thought embraces the common laws that are always at work in everything, the feelings that spring from the thought of the eternal will always have occasion to arise and will gradually gain the upper hand over the other passions. Our finite nature moreover entails that we must seek nourishment and strength in something outside us; therefore we cannot be freed from love as from the other passions. It is altogether an excellent thing that all passions that are good are of such a nature that without them we cannot be or exist. The more causes and points of attachment a passion has, the greater power it has. And this holds
[140] precisely of the passion that springs from the thought of the eternal and divine, which lies at the ground of everything. A clear and distinct knowledge brings joy with it, because our power of action reaches its fulfillment in it. And since this joy, when knowledge goes back to the first cause, has God as its cause, there arises the love of God, which is nourished by everything we know, and must therefore be the mightiest passion of all. Even if love of the unchangeable and eternal cannot entirely drive out the passions, it will nevertheless restrict them to the smallest part of the soul.

Intellectual love—so Spinoza calls (after Descartes and older Jewish philosophers of

religion) the joy in the eternal and infinite that springs from true knowledge—which is the transfigured passion, shows us man's essence from an entirely different side from the one from which we have so far considered it: no longer as an individual being, but as a being that, through its unity with the infinite fundamental being, acquires existence in itself and is eternally free. But this intellectual love is not merely a goal that man approaches and strives to reach. When the concept of God is thought according to the strict consistency of the system, the matter stands otherwise.—As absolute being God cannot pass over to greater or lesser perfection, and so cannot feel love or hatred toward anyone. One who would wish that God should love him in return would wish that God were not God. That God does not love men must not, however, be understood as though they were indifferent to him. Man and everything that is, is in God in such a way, and God consists of all beings in such a way, that he cannot feel love for anything or anyone, *[141]* since nothing is given outside his own essence. Man's love of God is a part of the infinite love with which God embraces his own essence. In it man regards himself as a member in, and form of, God's infinite essence. Since this cannot step forth in any definite form, "as an object among many others," intellectual love gets no object, does not really become love *for* anything. Therefore there can be no question of requited love either; the subject and object of the love are not different. It is, one may say, an immanent love; it has the same character as the acting of the fundamental being in general: God can only be an immanent (reflexive) cause, not act on anything outside himself.—This doctrine is not only consistent, but also contains the great truth that every ideal striving has its goal not outside itself but in itself. Blessedness, says Spinoza, is not the reward of virtue, but is virtue itself. For the mythological imagination the matter stands thus, that the labor is one thing, the reward another. But on Spinoza's view what holds is what stands in Heiberg's poem:

> In seeking him, you have already found him;
> In asking, the answer is already won.[29]

[29] "This being so, we may rightly declare it a great absurdity, what many who are otherwise regarded as great theologians say: that if no eternal life followed from the love of God, one would do best to seek one's own self, as though one could find in it something better than in God. This would be just as foolish as if a fish, which after all cannot live except in the water, were to say: If no eternal life follows for me after this life in the water, then I will out of the water, up onto land." *Spinoza*: "Short Treatise" II, 26. (Schaarschmidt's German translation).

[142] Intellectual love must, like true knowledge, be eternal, and has neither beginning nor end. In it man is, after all, one with the fundamental being and thus eternal as this is, and it is only owing to an inadequate knowledge that he is conceived as being in time. It does no harm to this eternity that we cannot remember having existed before our existence in time. Memory presupposes relations of time, but the eternal has nothing whatever to do with time. True knowledge, which sees everything under the aspect of eternity, is raised above sense representation and memory, which belong only to time. Most people, to be sure, are not able to reach this knowledge. Just as by God they imagine a single object, so by the eternity of the mind they understand a simple continuation and persistence of their existence in time. But the eternity of the mind signifies nothing other than its nature as a necessary element in the fundamental being (an eternal mode of thought, *æternus cogitandi modus*).

In this mystical doctrine of intellectual love Spinoza's philosophy bends back toward its main principle. After the experimental undercurrent has been the stronger in the course of the psychological and ethical investigations, religious speculation now again comes to the fore. The opposition between the two currents makes itself sharply felt here too, since Spinoza cuts off the possibility of reaching the ideal standpoint through finite
[143] development. Just as he denied, in an earlier connection, that the individual manifoldness of the individual beings could be derived from the fundamental being, so he now denies that the individual being can reach knowledge of the eternal through a development in time. The whole process of liberation we have seen man go through thus rests on an illusion,[30] the same illusion that is peculiar to the lowest form of knowledge: namely, that the existence given in experience, unfolding itself in time, has reality. In reality the fundamental being is the one thing existing, and man, as an element in its nature, is himself eternal—and so can be subject to no passive passions and go through no development.

Spinoza therefore abandons here too his earlier psychological determinations. He conceived joy, after all, as transition to greater perfection, and we stressed what is true in this determination. But it is no longer enough for him. In the absolute and eternal there can be no question of transition: therefore he says that in place of joy *(lætitia)* there

[30] This is one of the points that *Brøchner* has illuminated with great clarity in his monograph "Benedikt Spinoza" (Kbhvn. 1857). Chaps. 6 and 8.

now appears blessedness *(beatitudo)*, which consists in the mind's being in possession of perfection itself.—It is no wonder that Spinoza here has difficulty in making himself understood, and we in following him. A perfect conclusion and fulfillment conflicts with psychology. Psychology, just as much as physics and physiology, knows only relative forms of state. Spinoza's contemporary Thomas Hobbes saw this clearly and expressed it thus (*De homine* XI, 15): "If there is to be a final end, then, when it is reached, there *[144]* is nothing to strive for and desire; then there is nothing either that stands before man as a good; indeed he can no longer even have any feeling, for every feeling is bound up with desire or aversion, and not to feel is the same as not to live. The greatest good consists, on the contrary, in going forward as unhindered as possible to ever higher ends. Life is a constant motion, and when this motion cannot go in a straight line, it goes in a circle."—One will easily see that we here again stand at what has been mentioned several times, that all deductive speculation really makes ethics impossible, since the eternal fundamental being is the one thing that is. The law of relativity, on the other hand, shows us that our life, like everything we know, is conditioned, is a link in a great development. Labor and striving are thus not illusions, but the expression of a universally valid law. An existence of pure being without becoming is incomprehensible to us.

Plato too, with whom Spinoza has so much in common altogether, stopped at an insurmountable opposition between becoming and being. The ideal world in its eternity was for him true being, and the existence given in experience, where becoming, development, striving, and thus also ethical labor, belong, became in the end an inexplicable appearance. That is why the highest thing for Plato, as for Spinoza, was theory, the speculative intuition of the eternal. And yet Plato, like Spinoza, is distinguished by his deep psychological understanding of the nature of drive.

Spinoza is reminiscent here also of the religious mysticism that flourished at the end of the seventeenth century, especially within the Cartesian school (Fénélon, Malebranche). *[145]* He is in his way a champion of "disinterested love," and here stands side by side with the noble Archbishop of Cambray. The religious mystics too seek an immediate union with the eternal and yearn for a standpoint where time and finitude vanish. What separates Spinoza from them (apart from the opposition between his philosophy and their theology) is that they move essentially in the domain of feeling, he in that of thought.

Their disinterested love of the eternal is sentimental,[31] his is intellectual. He has, as Jakobi aptly said of him, his heaven in the understanding. It belongs to the one-sidedness of his psychology that he sees the essence of the mind exhausted in thought. Will is only assent to the truth known, feeling only a confused thought. In his doctrine of the passions he shows how these by a metamorphosis pass over into becoming thoughts. Pure intellectual activity is for him the proper essence of the mind. It was only toward the end of the eighteenth century that psychology became properly clear about the peculiarity and independence of feeling as a mental phenomenon beside knowledge and will. It was surely the eighteenth century's bringing forward of individuality, its significance and its right, that opened people's eyes here. Feeling has a more individual character than the other expressions of mental life. We can to a certain degree think and act like others, but feel only as ourselves.

[146] Allen gehört was du denkst, dein eigen ist nur,
was du fühlest!
(Schiller).

Spinoza could, to be sure, immerse himself in the contemplation of the individual emotions and their laws, but he nevertheless always sought beyond this individual element to the deep unity and the great whole into which, for him, everything individual flows out as it reaches its fulfillment. His personal character seems moreover to have been decidedly contemplative; to be moved by hope and fear, by the many changing moods under which most men's personal lives develop and must develop, was foreign to him, because he had once and for all dedicated himself to knowledge and gathered up his personal development into the development of thought. Feeling appears in him as the mild glow, the quiet joy, that knowledge won spreads around it; the quiet shores where he dwelt were not visited by life's more violent breakers.

V.

[147] However solitary and withdrawn a position Spinoza occupies in his thinking and in his life, all his writings nevertheless bear the stamp of his having felt himself to be "a man

[31] This word used in its proper, not in its pejorative, sense.

among men." The task he had set himself, and whose solution he regarded as the highest good, the knowledge of our mind's connection with the whole of nature, could, by his conviction, be reached not by the individual for himself alone, but only in community with others. The solution of the task therefore presupposes partly a reformation of knowledge, partly the formation of a society in which as many as possible are educated and developed toward the stated goal. In his ethical doctrine we see how the strength of mind that for him signifies the highest development of character appears not only as courage (in the individual's own affairs), but also as generosity (in relation to others).—The ethical character presupposes a development that is not present in all, and when the question therefore becomes one of the foundation of human society, we must go further back, back to the same point from which ethical development began: man as a mere natural being, subject to the dominion of passive passions. The essence and origin of the state cannot be understood unless one understands the nature of passion. Spinoza therefore stresses here, as in the Ethics, the necessity of studying passion like any other natural phenomenon. *[148]* Statesmen, he says, have written far better about politics than philosophers, because the former have followed experience, while the latter have censured the passions and constructed a state for pure beings of reason, who do not exist, or who in any case need no laws. Experience presents so many different forms of state that we can hardly devise anything altogether new that the necessary demands of practical life would not have brought to light in some place or other.—Since men are led essentially by the passions, against which the dictates of reason and religion avail but little, the state must be so ordered that nothing is left entirely to the fidelity and morality of individuals, but that those who rule are prevented by their own interest from acting dishonestly, whatever disposition might then lie at the ground of their acting. Freedom and strength of mind are a private virtue; and in the state, where security for all is what counts first and foremost, one dare not count on it.

Every natural being is a finite form of the infinite fundamental being, and the power by which it exists, acts and asserts itself in its existence is a part of the infinite power of the divine being. Therefore every natural being originally has—whether it is led by reason or passion—just as much right as it has power. Natural right is one with natural power, or with the law of nature that originally determines the individual's action. It is thus by a natural right that the big fish devour the small. For each individual, what

[149] he regards as good and evil is determined by his interest. He keeps a given promise, for example, only so far as it agrees with his own advantage. If a robber has forced me to promise to hand over my fortune to him, I do not hesitate to break this promise when I can do so without danger. In the state of nature nothing is forbidden except what no one thinks of doing. Now since the passions—especially anger, hatred and envy—bring men into conflict with one another, they are by nature enemies. The one must always fear the other. Under these conditions there exists no property—each possesses only what he has the power to defend—and no security. But for that reason natural right does not really exist at all as long as it is determined by each one's power. Only by united forces can men sustain their lives and cultivate their minds. One can therefore say that man is a social being: his natural conditions lead him to the founding of a social life. The more there are who unite their forces, the greater the power, security and right they possess.

When such a society is founded, individuals in part hand over their right to the power of the community *(imperium)*. What the power of the community declares right and wrong, individuals must do or refrain from. Each individual now has only the right the power of the community grants him. But how far does the right of society extend? Only so far as its actual power extends. Society rests on the principle that a passion can be checked only by another, stronger passion, and that man must therefore be kept from inflicting harm on others by the fear of suffering greater harm himself. What society
[150] cannot compel man to do, it has no right to command. The power of the community must therefore, according to the law of self-preservation, which is one with the dictate of reason, command nothing that would put an end to its own dominion. Just as the individual is strongest when he follows reason, so only that society can last which is determined by reason. To say that the power of the community may do what it pleases is the same as to say that a man may take leave of his senses. It came into being to help individuals to their natural right and must therefore seek what is most useful for all. What conflicts with human nature and outrages human feeling the power of the state cannot command without aiming at its own downfall. It then itself becomes an evil for man of the same kind as those he suffered under in the state of nature; individuals will seek means of securing themselves against it—and society will thus be dissolved. In particular the state would overstep its right if it sought to intervene in the domain of free conviction, where threats and promises avail nothing. No one can sign away his judgment or prevent

another from using his. In spite of all prohibitions and all compulsion men will love and hate as agrees with their nature.

There is thus no absolute opposition between life in the state of nature and life in society. On this point Spinoza differs from his contemporary Thomas Hobbes, who taught that the drive of self-preservation, which leads men beyond the state of nature, this war of all against all, commands complete submission to the will of the power of the state as *[151]* the only means of securing peace. Spinoza grants that every member of society must, admittedly, give up the right to live as he himself sees fit; in place of his own decision as to what is good and evil, he must now follow that of the state. Nor can he have the right to interpret the laws in his own way, for then he would be his own judge, and it was precisely in order to have a common measure of right and wrong that the state was founded. But the resignation that must be shown here does not conflict with reason. Even if in some cases I must do what I myself do not consider right, I nevertheless choose the lesser of two evils: it would be a far greater evil if social life were dissolved and the state of nature began again!

The origin of the state is thus, according to Spinoza, to be sought in human egoism. To avoid the violent clash of interests one hands over to society as a whole the care of the common welfare. But Spinoza does not see the task of the state exhausted in mere security. Its purpose is not merely to rule and by fear to keep one from harming another. Of a state whose citizens are kept only by fear from taking up arms against one another, one can rather say that it is without war than that it has peace. Peace is not merely the absence of war; true peace proceeds from strength of mind and from adherence to the common laws of the state. It is precisely the task of the state to banish fear entirely. The state does not aim at turning men into machines or irrational animals, but at making a spiritual life possible. The end of the state is therefore freedom. That this end is not *[152]* reached must be ascribed not so much to the wickedness of the citizens as to the badness of the constitution. Where discord, rebellion and contempt for the laws prevail, it must be because the institutions are no good. For men are not born citizens, but must develop into becoming such.

Spinoza regards democracy as both the most natural and the most perfect constitution. It is most natural that men should not at once hand over the whole of power to one person or a few, but to the whole assembled multitude that agrees to create a society.

Each individual then, since he himself belongs to the multitude, gets a share in future deliberations on the use of the power of the state. Thereby hope rather than fear also becomes the foundation of society. The most perfect constitution is democracy, because it comes nearest to the freedom that belongs to each by nature.

Spinoza is the first modern political writer to have declared himself for a democratic republic. The republican writers before him in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries were more or less aristocrats. He is in this respect Rousseau's predecessor. He grants, however, that if the patricians let themselves be led not by their passions but by regard for the public good, an aristocratic constitution would be best of all; but such a presupposition he regards as contrary to experience. Unfortunately he died just as he had begun, in his Political Treatise, to set forth the democratic constitution, so that we cannot see what
[153] special institutions he considered necessary under it.[32] On the other hand he sets forth in detail the institutions of aristocracy and monarchy. He seeks to show how both rulers and ruled—with or against their will—can be brought to act according to the dictate of reason. An absolute monarchy is impossible, since the king needs counselors, on whom he will always be more or less dependent, and the constitution will thus in reality become aristocratic. The kingship Spinoza describes corresponds to what we call a constitutional monarchy *(imperium monarchicum, qvod a libera multitudine instituitur).* The king is even bound to choose among the proposals that have received the most votes in the great council, in which the whole people is represented. The judicial power is exercised by a separate body. An absolute autocracy would, if it were possible, perhaps lead to greater security, and state secrets could be better kept under such a constitution; but these advantages would be bought by giving up far more essential goods. When the
[154] autocrat has nothing to take into account but his own pleasure, one has no guarantee that he will strive for the general good, whereas he will naturally be an enemy of all eminent men who might seem to dispute his rank. After Spinoza has discussed the forms and institutions by which the royal power ought to be restricted, he remarks that his

[32]The last paragraph in the unfinished treatise, and thus probably the last thing Spinoza wrote before his death, deals with the question how far women in a democratic republic ought to have equal rights with men. If women were by nature equal to men, history—Spinoza thinks—would have offered examples of such equality of rights. Moreover, women could not without great inconvenience have a share in political power: the erotic drive and the passions it brings with it (jealousy, etc.) would then interfere disruptively.—The first of these objections Stuart Mill has thoroughly refuted in his well-known work; the second, on the other hand, he does not mention at all.

account will perhaps provoke laughter in those who are accustomed to imagining all vices on the side of the multitude and all virtues among the great. But human nature is one and the same in all, and precisely those who rule are by their position exposed to many faults.

The starting point of Spinoza's political theory[33] is the natural right of the individual, which is not to be given up but precisely to be secured and developed in social life. He is here a predecessor of the eighteenth century and its struggle for the rights of the individual. Kant's proposition of freedom—in the sense of independence of the coercive arbitrariness of anyone else—as the one original human right, and the development that Wilhelm von Humboldt and Stuart Mill have given this proposition, is in principle stated in Spinoza. And what is surprising in a speculative and abstract philosopher: the working out of his doctrine has everywhere a practical and real character and is built on sharp psychological insight.

But although Spinoza recognizes no complete opposition between the state of nature *[155]*
and social life, he nevertheless regards them as different and has the transition from the one to the other take place by a compact. It was a notion that was often taken as a basis in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, and that sprang essentially from defective insight into the laws of human (and all) development. Just as in geology the present state of the earth used to be thought of as the result of a series of great revolutions and quite different from earlier states, so the transition between the different states of human life was thought of as an arbitrary act. Such abrupt transitions a more developed psychological and historical insight does not admit. The law of continuity reigns here too. In spite of all drastic events and catastrophes, social life has developed essentially under the same laws on which it now rests, by a quiet, often imperceptible growth. —

There is a close connection between Spinoza's political theory and his doctrine of religion. In his "Theologico-Political Treatise" he sought, on the basis of his doctrine of the relation between faith and knowledge, theology and philosophy, to show the possibility and necessity of religious freedom. And in the political theory we have seen that there is a domain into which the power of the community cannot penetrate, namely

[33] Spinoza's political theory stands—not merely for its own time—alone in clarity, consistency and liberal-mindedness. But no doubt owing to his isolated position he had in this domain, as well as in psychology, to stand in the shadow of Hobbes, although the latter's paradoxical and shortsighted pessimism, at least at first glance, seemed to make him an opponent of progress.

the individual's free conviction. His external actions the state can determine, but religion belongs essentially to the inner life and consists in the knowledge of the divine and in love of one's neighbor. The external forms of worship are indifferent, and the religious
[156] man will show his love precisely by preserving peace in society and not stirring up discord by sectarian conduct.

The religiousness that corresponds to Spinoza's standpoint he himself defines thus: "Everything we desire and do, insofar as we are led by the idea of God, I refer to religion. The desire to do good that arises from our living according to the dictate of reason I call piety." But since this philosophical concept of religion conflicts with the theological conception of it, he seeks to determine more closely the relation between theology and philosophy. The theological concept of religion rests on the idea of a revelation. Here, of course, there is no talk of revelation in the wider sense of the word, in which all knowledge we gain of nature can be called revelation, even if we use only "the natural light." Revelation, in the strict sense of the word, is different from rational knowledge: it does not come, as this does, through clear and distinct concepts, but takes place through words and signs. Not all can receive such words and signs and communicate them to others; for that, individuals with a special gift are required, who are called prophets. But this special gift cannot consist in eminent understanding and knowledge, since it is, after all, not pure thoughts but images and symbols that are to be apprehended and communicated. What counts is rather, above all, a strong and lively imagination. There is a natural opposition between individuals in whom imagination is most developed and those in whom understanding is; the one of these faculties is commonly developed at the expense of the other. That is why it is a great misunderstanding to seek knowledge of
[157] the nature of the world and of the mind in the writings of the prophets. Such knowledge must be gained in an entirely different way. How, indeed, should a warrior like Joshua understand astronomy, or Noah geography? Why, Adam did not even know that God was omniscient, since he hid among the trees of the garden; nor did Abraham know it, since he asked God to count how many righteous men there were in Sodom. The prophets had, moreover, to accommodate themselves to those to whom they spoke. Only of Christ does it hold that he was not governed by imagination, but received revelation by immediate and true knowledge. It is, as we have heard Spinoza say in one of his letters (above, p. 49), not necessary to know the historical Christ ("Christ after the flesh"), but

"the Son of God" in the sense of the eternal wisdom that reveals itself in all things, most in the human mind, and most of all in Christ, who taught men to know the universal law of reason. In the Sermon on the Mount Spinoza sees, like modern rationalism, the sum of true Christianity. The law of Moses was a national and political institution that lapsed with the downfall of the Jewish kingdom. The Jews have nothing to boast of over against other peoples. Nations other than the Jews too have had prophets; it is not something peculiar to the Jewish people.

Revelation acquires a different character in the different prophets, since their personality, bodily constitution and previous opinions necessarily come to influence their preaching. The courtier Isaiah speaks differently from the shepherd Amos. One cannot therefore without further ado use the writings of the one to interpret those of the other. *[158]* On the basis of sure knowledge of the language and acquaintance with the author's life, the historical circumstances and the authenticity of the text, one must find the actual meaning of each particular passage. Whether this meaning is true in itself is an entirely different question. We cannot without further ado start from the assumption that Scripture agrees with reason; that would lead to the consequence that the final ecclesiastical authority would have to be sought among the philosophers, but this authority would hardly meet with great respect. What Scripture teaches, and how far what it teaches is true, are thus two entirely different questions.

Spinoza, who is the first to have spoken for a purely historical interpretation of Scripture, is also the first to have applied a historical criticism to the biblical books. He maintains that the authenticity of each particular writing must be proved for itself, and comes to the conclusion that the Old Testament writings in their present form cannot have the authors whose names they bear.

The difficulties at which the scientific interpretation of Scripture comes to a halt need not, however, according to Spinoza, trouble those who seek edification in Scripture. What is edifying in Scripture *(pietatis documenta)* can always be easily understood. And the real aim of the prophets was to proclaim a doctrine that could lead to piety and to obedience to God. That is why they present God as a lawgiver and prince whom men must obey. Theology differs from philosophy precisely in teaching that men are saved by obedience, whereas philosophy maintains that true virtue springs from insight into *[159]* the connection of nature. Theology seeks piety, philosophy seeks truth. Truth is in itself

neither pious nor impious. Only insofar can one say that there is piety or impiety in a man's opinions as he takes occasion from them for obedience or disobedience. One who becomes arrogant by believing what is true has an impious faith; one who becomes obedient by believing what is false, a pious one. The faith that is to be common to all men can therefore include nothing about which honest men can disagree. When it is demanded that one believe in God, then by God must be understood an ideal pattern for human life *(veræ vitæ exemplar)*, but it is indifferent how each thinks of God—as fire or light, spirit, thought, in a pantheistic or theological way, etc. Here the differences of intellectual gift and development come to play a role. All can obey and lead a life in justice and love, but not all can acquire a knowledge grounded in reason.

By referring positive religion to the practical domain Spinoza seeks to secure the freedom of science. He leaves piety to theology, but reserves truth for philosophy, a division with which the theologians could not be entirely satisfied. One is tempted to regard such a division as ironically meant, and yet no irony can be traced in Spinoza's account. It is clear, however, that it was not his real meaning thereby to set faith and knowledge side by side as equals. Truth stands for him above piety and regulates it, not
[160] the reverse. He not only remarks that, in order to bow in the obedience of faith, one must not know that what one believes is untrue. He even says that it is impossible for philosophy to see that men are saved by obedience, because obedience takes account only of the will of the one who commands, not of the necessity and truth of the matter. Further, in his "Theologico-Political Treatise" he criticizes miracle from a purely philosophical point of view: since nature is one with God, one cannot, as in the belief in miracles, appeal from the power of nature to the power of God, and it is no use saying that miracle is above, not against, nature, since miracle, after all, happens in the midst of nature and so interrupts its order. And finally he states outright that the prophets, only because of their defective knowledge, presented God as lawgiver and prince instead of as the eternal and infinite fundamental being. They did so in order to accommodate themselves to the comprehension of the multitude. Most people do not do good for its own sake and from love of it, but because they fear an almighty lawgiver and are moved by the reward and punishment he has laid down. The multitude likewise needs ceremonies and historical narratives and examples that can make an impression on its imagination. Rational arguments make no impression on it. One who uses his reason, on the other

hand, does not need historical religion. The law is given only for the unfree, not for those who have "the fruits of the Spirit" and possess true knowledge.

There thus remains a definite opposition between those who know and those who believe. They are two different views of life that stand over against each other. And the *[161]* opposition is rather aptly stated by Spinoza's antithesis: obedience—truth. What separates the two tendencies is, namely, essentially the different conception of the significance of authority: positive faith holds fast that there are absolute authorities; rational faith knows only relative authorities. Spinoza has not, however, brought out the historical relation between the two tendencies, which, viewed abstractly, are altogether irreconcilable opposites. For historical reality shows us authorities as educating powers in the human world, and there takes place a constant giving and receiving between the two poles; in the course of history they constantly determine each other. If one compares the series of religions, and of authorities in general, in history, one will find that the higher ones always have a more rational character. On the other hand authority is—as Spinoza himself has shown in his political theory—a necessary support for developing freedom. Just as the universe, in the opinion of some astronomers, shows us groups of stars at very different stages of development from chaos to system, so we see at all times in the human world many different stages of development from authority to freedom. And Spinoza has shown by his own example that the transition from the one standpoint to the other does not entail the abandonment of true religiousness. The religious need can find its satisfaction in more forms than the dogmatism of positive religion admits. Spinoza's innermost line of thought was of a religious character, if by religiousness one understands devotion to *[162]* the higher connection of which the individual is a member. A feeling of this connection is the lifeblood of his system.—

Systematic a mind as Spinoza was, men must nevertheless, by his conviction, seek satisfaction for their religious need each in his own way. The mental nature of men *(ingenium)* is so different that they cannot find rest in the same opinions. The power of the community will therefore only do harm and work against itself if it seeks to violate freedom of thought and speech. Each is master of his conviction and must have the right to express it, provided he does not do so in a way that can stir up hatred and rebellion in the state. Piety and impiety concern, after all, as we have heard, not opinions in themselves, but the actions that spring from opinions. If the state were to intervene in

the domain of free conviction, it would meet resistance precisely in the noblest and best men. Those who think only of amassing money and tending their bellies would naturally not care about such an intervention. But what greater misfortune can be conceived for a state than that honorable men be sent into exile as criminals because they hold peculiar views and do not know how to dissemble? What is more terrible than that men be led to death, not on account of any crime or misdeed, but on account of their free cast of mind? Freedom may, to be sure, entail inconveniences; but there are so many inconveniences
[163] one must put up with in order to obtain the greater goods.—Who, in any case, should have the right to intervene in the individual's conviction? One cannot appeal here to any divine authority. God can only falsely be represented as prince and lawgiver; the divine law is one with the necessity of eternal nature. History, particularly the history of the Jews, shows plainly enough that it leads to dubious consequences when the clergy obtains political power. The state must therefore have the right to order external worship as agrees with its welfare. But the best arrangement is nevertheless that the various religious parties obtain freedom to exist side by side. Spinoza cites Amsterdam as an example of such an arrangement being carried through without unfortunate consequences. Nothing is safer for the state than that piety and religiousness be placed only in love and justice, and that the right of the authorities, in sacred as in secular matters, be restricted to actions alone, while each is otherwise allowed to think what he will and to say what he thinks.

Spinoza could no doubt have gone still further and restricted the right of the power of the community to intervene even in the domain of actions still more. In this direction Kant and Stuart Mill have continued his line of thought. But it is already a great thing that, in the midst of the dogmatism and rule of authority of the seventeenth century, he stated the principle of freedom of thought and speech. He shows here how little right people have so often had to deny him an eye for the significance of personality.
[164] As his religious and philosophical conviction was in harmony with his clear, quiet and yet energetic personality, so he also shows a deep understanding of the significance of personal conviction for the full and rich development of human life.

List of the Most Important Philosophical Terms and the Places in the Book Where Their Meaning Can Be Seen

[The page numbers are those of the original edition, given in the margin of this translation. *[165]* The Danish equivalents in parentheses are the author's.]

Absolute (cf. relative). 69–71. 97 f.

Anthropomorphism (conception of the divine under human forms). 118.

Atheism. 54–58.

Attribute (*Grundform*, fundamental form). 70 f. 73 ff. 80 f. 89 f.

Deduction, deductive (cf. induction). 6. 14 f. 44–46. 68. 95.

Deism, deist. 54–59.

Determinism (*Nødvendighedslære*, doctrine of necessity), deterministic. 26. 49. 51–54. 120 ff.

Discursive (cf. intuitive). 110 ff.

Dogmatism, dogmatic. 4–6. 118.

Dualism (*Tohedslære*, doctrine of twoness), dualistic (cf. monism). 7–8. 59. 94. 107.

Empiricism, empirical. See induction.

Immanence (*Iboen*, indwelling), immanent. 48. 83. 141.

Induction (*Erfaringsmetode*, method of experience), inductive. 6. 12–15. 44–46. 76–79. 106 f. 110.

Intuition (*anskuende Tænken*, intuiting thought), intuitive. 110–115.

Critical philosophy (cf. dogmatism). 4–6.

Mode (*Enkeltvæsen*, individual being). 73. 84 ff.

Monad. 67. 71. 93 f.

Monism (*Enhedslære*, doctrine of unity), monistic (cf. dualism). 8. 59.

Optimism. 31. 134 ff.

Pantheism, pantheist. 8–10. 53. 57–59. 82. 140–141

Relation (*Forhold*), relativity (*Betingethed*, conditionedness), relative. 59. 70 f. 81. 88. 118 f. 130. 143 f.

Speculation, speculative. 2. 13. 16. 86 f. 97 f.

Substance (*Grundvæsen*, fundamental being). 6–9. 17. 26. 67. 70 f. 72 ff. 76 ff.

Theism. 53, cf. 57.

Translation of the French Verse on Page 56; Note to Page 127; Errata

Translation of the French Verse on Page 56

[166]

Then came a little, sallow and long-nosed Jew,
Poor but content, thoughtful, turned inward,
A fine, subtle mind, less read than acknowledged.
Wrapped in the garments of Descartes, his master,
Slowly he steps before the Most High
And whispers softly to him: “Pardon me, I would
Confide to you, unter uns, I do not believe you exist.”

H. T.

Note to Page 127

A note ought to have been added here to the effect that Spinoza is surely not right in applying the laws of the association of ideas directly to the feelings. It deserves in any case closer psychological investigation whether the one feeling can directly call forth the other, or whether the way from the one feeling to the other does not rather go through the thoughts and representations attached to the feeling and the associations of ideas that these call forth. Any thing can thus indirectly become a cause of joy, sorrow and desire, not because these feelings pass directly over into one another, but because various representations are attached to the thing, of which the one awakens joy, the other sorrow, etc. A memory will, for example, awaken joy when the representation of the earlier

happiness is predominant, but sorrow when that representation is succeeded by the representation that this happiness is now over.

Errata

P. 8, l. 5 from bottom: for *for* read *fra.*
P. 10 [i.e. 104], l. 3 from bottom: for *hallucition* read *hallucination.*
P. 132, l. 11 from bottom: for *gneerositas* read *generositas.*